



THE GUARDIANS OF ELARIA

SESSION 8

Underroot

An illustrated adventure. Read the gold boxes aloud; the purple boxes are for the DM.



One door, one world, and something on the far side that has been waiting two years for help.

Previously, on The Guardians of Elaria...

In the clockwork city of **Gearhaven** the heroes found the **Grand Custodian**, the great machine that makes the city's heartbeat, caught and corrupted almost to breaking. They freed it instead of destroying it, and the city's wounds closed behind them on their own. That is the rule that governs everything now: **a crack between worlds cannot be sealed from our side, but free a world's guardian and its cracks close themselves.**

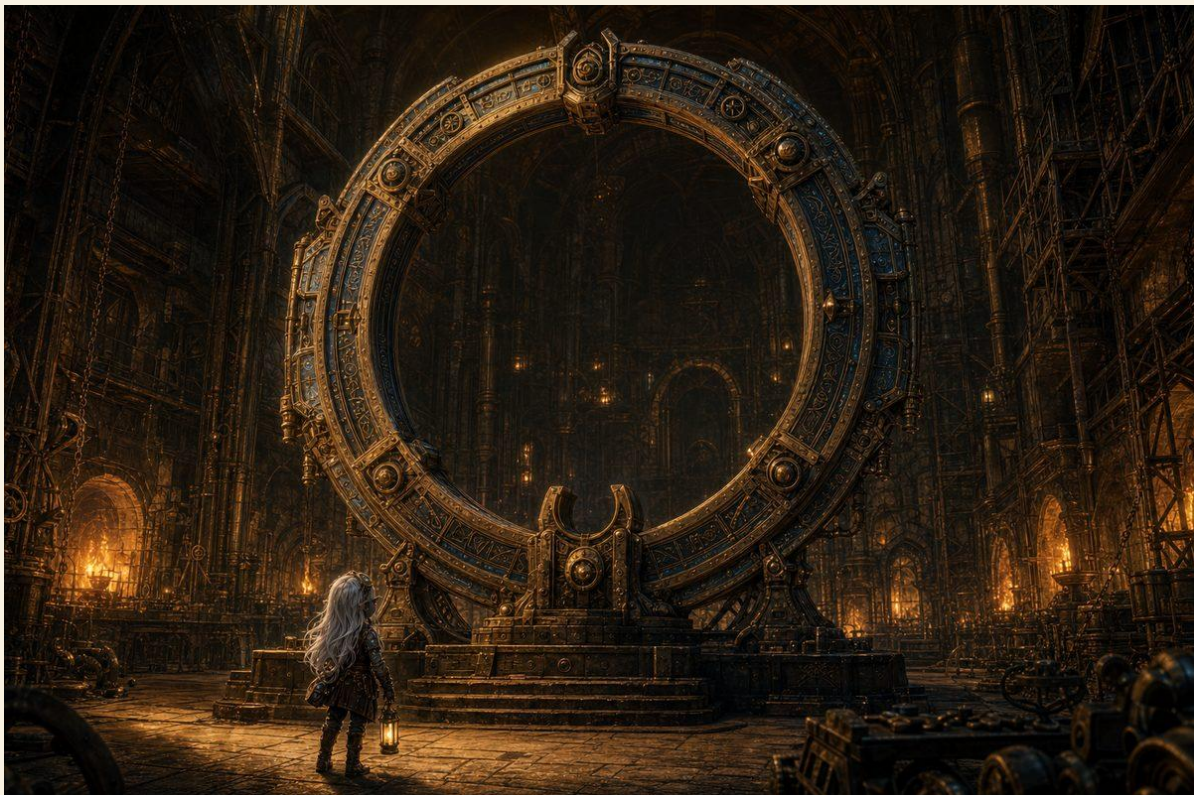
Guildmaster Vane showed them his life's work: a ring of brass, ten years in the building, that could open a door to another world. It lacked one thing, an anchor, and the **Essence Sphere** is that anchor. Through Ursa's Mark, Pikachu's spark warned them in pictures instead of words: a vast hunger, a shadow that walks ahead of it, and the spark's own dread that it is *a key. To something.*

The ring needed a year to finish. So the three of them went their separate ways, each with a question only a year could answer. **This session opens on the day they come back.**

► The heroes return at **level 7**. Do not hand out the new sheets yet; they land during **The Handover**, so the fiction and the paperwork arrive in the same beat. Part One is read like a chapter. Part Two is played on the Underroot board.

Part One: The Year Apart

Four arrivals, one long dinner, and a door that has never been opened.



The lamp at the foot of the ring has been burning all week.

Seven Days Early

The Artificer's Guild never quite sleeps, but at midnight it comes close. Down in the Underworks the furnaces are banked to a low orange mutter, and the great ring of the portal stands in the middle of the Rift Hall like something dreaming. The Rift Hall is the tall room at the head of the Underworks, galleried and railed the whole way around, and its clerestory windows sit above the roofline, so that even down here a person can look up and find a piece of the Gearhaven sky.

Lilly Glimmergear has been here a week. She told herself it was to check the anchor housing. Really it was because she could not stand another night of waiting somewhere else. The ring is finished. Ten years of Guildmaster Vane's life, finished for two weeks now, and nobody has dared to switch it on.

► **Three things to land during Lilly's week. Vane has aged:** ten years of work ended two weeks ago and he does not know what to do with his hands, so he is louder than usual, sleeping less, and will not say he is frightened. **Lilly is the expert now:** the guild artificers ask her opinion and mean it. And **the cradle does not quite fit**, because Vane built it from drawings of a sphere he had only had described to him. When Lilly finally sets the real thing in on the sixth night, the brass closes around it as though it were cut for it. Play that quiet. It is the first hint of what she learned this year.

The Professor

On the third morning of Lilly's week, three trunks arrive at the Guild gate, and behind them comes Professor Aelwyn Ravenstone. He is exactly as everyone remembers him and slightly worse: tall, silver haired, entirely certain, and delighted to be proven wrong about anything as long as he is the one doing the proving.

He looks at the ring for a long moment. Then at the Sphere in its cradle. Then he says, to nobody in particular:

"Oh. That is much older than you think it is."

He says it the way other people say good morning.

Nobody sent for him, and nobody needed to. There is no one alive who knows the planes, or the creatures that fall out of them, the way Aelwyn Ravenstone does. He has spent thirty years studying the far sides of doors that were never supposed to open, and now one is about to open on purpose, and he intends to be standing at it when it does. The trunks are full of field guides, and he wrote most of them himself.

By noon he has claimed the gallery above the ring and turned it into a field camp: four brass instruments nobody can name, a folding desk, and a kettle he will defend with his life. He asks every artificer who passes what the ring sounds like at night, writes down all nine answers, and underlines two of them. When Vane finally climbs up to object, the two of them argue happily for an hour about anchor harmonics, and the objection is never mentioned again.

He is here for the week. Everyone understands that without being told, the same way everyone has quietly stopped scheduling anything for the day the ring opens.



Three trunks, no porters, and one small green passenger who did not pay a fare.

► **Lickgloom remembers them.** He stayed behind at Ravenstone Laboratory two years ago and has spent the time since licking a professor's equipment. He rode the luggage the whole way here. He recognises each hero on sight as they arrive through the week, and he is beside himself about it every single time. Give this a beat: it is the only uncomplicated happy reunion in the whole session.

Dawn, and the Eastern Gate

Ursa Catchum comes in with the dawn traffic, on foot, with road dust to his knees. He is taller. That is the first thing anyone notices. The second is that he is quiet in a way he never used to be. He waits half a beat before he answers a question, as though he is listening to something a half second behind the voice. In his left hand is a stone that he turns over and over without seeming to know he is doing it.

He has been walking east for a year. He does not look like someone who found what he was looking for, but he does not look like someone who failed, either.

The first thing he does inside the gate is stop, and look up, and stand there long enough that the morning crowd has to part around him: checking the eastern sky against something he carries in his head. Whatever he finds there, he keeps to himself. Then he shoulders his pack and walks down into the waking city, toward the Guild, without needing to ask the way.

Ten to Midnight

On the last night of the year apart, the bell over the Rift Hall doors has not rung all evening. It does not ring now either, because the goblin coming through them does not touch them.

He is on the rail above everyone before anybody thinks to look up. He is leaner, and there is a new sword across his back, dark and quiet, and when he drops down into the lamplight he lands without a sound, which he absolutely never used to do.

"I'm not late," says Stabby Sharpblade. "It's still today."



First light on the Eastern Gate, and nobody recognises the traveller until he has already passed.



Ten minutes in hand, and he has almost certainly been in Gearhaven since the afternoon.

► **The idol, lightly.** When Stabby swings his pack down, something inside knocks against the flagstones with a dull, wrong sound. It is the small carved idol that appeared in his bag after Wraithpine, which nobody has ever explained and no one saw put there. Tonight, forty feet from a portal that is not even lit, **it is cold enough to burn.** He has carried it a year and it has never done that. Do not explain it tonight, and do not promise anything; just let it sit.

And then, for the first time in a year, all of you are standing in the same room. Nobody makes a speech. Stabby hugs Lilly hard enough to lift her off the floor, and Ursa puts a hand on each of their shoulders, and Lickgloom licks everyone whether they consent or not. Vane watches from the gallery rail and pretends he is checking a gauge. Tomorrow the ring opens. Tonight there is a year to account for.

One Long Dinner at the Gilded Gear

Three heroes, three stories, and a kitchen that has been told to keep the fire lit.

The Gilded Gear keeps its back room for guild business, and Vane has declared this guild business. The table is long, the food keeps coming, and nobody has to be anywhere until morning.

Three of you have a year to tell. So you go around the table, and the telling takes most of the night, and nobody minds at all.

► **Each chapter is a told tale.** The hero telling it is at the table; hand that player the floor before you begin, and read the chapter with them, letting them interrupt and add colour. It is their year. This order builds best: Lilly's tale is the most hopeful, Stabby's is the loudest, and Ursa's changes the shape of the campaign, so it goes last.

Lilly Tells It: The Year of Questions

Lilly goes first, because she has props. She lifts the Essence Sphere onto the table between the bread and the butter, which alarms everyone, and pats it like an old friend, and begins with the morning she carried it up her mother's lane.

► **Hand Lilly's player the floor.** Everything below happened during her year, and she was there for all of it; invite her to tell parts of it in her own words.



Deepforge Hollow, and a mother with flour on her hands.

She went home first. That surprised everyone, Lilly included. She set the Essence Sphere on her mother's kitchen table and said: tell me everything.

It was the least satisfying conversation of her life. Poots told her about the day she brought the Sphere home, about the long nights fitting the brass around it, about the sigil work along the equator that took seventeen tries to get right. She talked like a craftsman describing a commission.

And Lilly, who had grown up on her mother's stories, noticed the one thing the story never touched. **Poots never once said where the thing inside the brass had come from.**

The Trade Roads

So she went looking.
She earned her answers out of Master Sparkwick at Glimmerspire, one stubborn question at a time, and his verdict sent her down the trade roads. She paid a dozen artificers the only way she could, with work.

She spent a season with a clockmaker who could not cast a single spell and whose escapements humbled her anyway, then weeks on the road between one workshop and the next with the Sphere wrapped in wool at the bottom of her pack, then two more passes through Gearhaven with Vane shouting about tolerances.

By midwinter her craft had gone from clever to formidable, and she still did not have her answer.



The verdict at Glimmerspire took him most of a morning to say out loud.

The Hands Workshop

The best six weeks were with a woman who built hands for injured miners. Brass fingers, clever joints, work that had to be right because somebody's whole life would hang on it. Lilly learned more about listening to a mechanism in that workshop than in any year of her life. She took the Sphere to wizards too, because wizards ask what a thing is. One of them fainted. Another wrote her four increasingly frantic letters. None of them knew.



Every joint on the bench is for somebody waiting to go back to work.

The Forty-First Opening

The answer was in the brass the whole time.
On the forty-first time she opened the housing, she stopped admiring her mother's sigils and looked *underneath* them. And there they were: older marks, in another hand, on a surface that should have been the inside of her mother's shell and was instead the outside of something else.



Lantern light and a loupe: forty openings were one too few.

Lilly looks around the dinner table and says it plainly, because she has checked it forty-one times and it is proof, not theory.

Her mother did not make the Essence Sphere. Poots Glimmergear found it, understood it was worth protecting, and spent a year of her own life building it a house. And the thing Lilly worked out on a workshop floor a long way from home: **it is a gatherer.** It was built to pull in loose planar essence and hold it. It held Pikachu because Pikachu's spark was loose, and the Sphere does not know the difference between a scrap of stray fire and somebody's friend. You cannot pick a gatherer's lock; all you can do is give it something to gather.

So she stopped building at it, and started listening to it.

► **What she brings back.** *Aether Channeler:* she can draw the **Aether Ward** out of the Sphere, **2d8 + 5 temporary hit points** to herself and every friend within 30 feet, **twice per short rest**. The five great discharges sleep until each plane's Mote comes home; **her power now grows by going out,**

which is the whole point. Also *Flash of Genius*: +5 to a failed check or save for her or any friend within 30 feet, five times a day.

Stabby Tells It: The Year He Went Back

Stabby waits until the plates are cleared, then climbs onto his chair, because his story requires standing up.

It starts, he says, a long time before this year. It starts with a clan that had one joke, and the joke was him.

► **Hand Stabby's player the floor.** This chapter runs from his childhood to the day he came back; let him act out as much of it as he wants.

Every clan has one child who is a problem, and the Bloodfang had Stabby.

Goblin children learn the clan's arts from the time they can stand, and the arts simply did not take with him. Every stance slid right off, and not because he was lazy or stupid. The word the clan used was *unteachable*, and in a clan with exactly one measure of a person's worth, everyone had quietly agreed by the time he was five what he was going to be.

So he became the joke on purpose. If they were going to laugh anyway, he wanted to be the one who decided what they laughed at.

Then **Skitch** came. The young Bloodfang courier the party pulled half-dead out of the machinery under Gearhaven had been sent a very long way to find the only Bloodfang anyone could name who had gone out into the world and come back alive from anything. Stabby laughed at him, because the clan asking for help was the clan that had spent his whole childhood explaining he was not worth teaching. Then he stopped laughing, packed in about four minutes, and went.

Bloodthorn Hollow was dying, and the blight took the strongest first. The biggest hunter, then the second biggest, then on down the list. The Bloodfang had one law, which was that the biggest goblin wins, and something in the woods was eating them in order.

By the time Stabby walked back in, the clan was mostly the small ones, the overlooked ones, and he knew every single one of them, because he had been the smallest of them once.

He saved them the way he does everything, fast and loud and extremely well: eleven weeks of hunting, the whole Hollow moved twice over furious objection, traps a cleverer person would not have thought of. By the end of summer the Bloodfang were not dying anymore.

But he knew he had not fixed it, only outrun it, because Candyfang went through the corrupted things the way a knife goes through smoke: clean through, and nothing changed.

The Fourth



Nokk waited nine years for somebody to ask the right question.

It was old Nokk who finally told him why, by a banked fire, in the voice goblins save for things that must only be said once.

His father was the Fourth. The fourth leader the Bloodfang ever named, and by every account the best of them. Nine years ago something came out of the deep woods, and the Fourth went to meet it alone, and he did not kill it, because it was not the kind of thing that can be killed. **He sealed it.** The only vessel to hand that night was his newborn son, and it cost him his life to do it.

The clan is not named Bloodfang for their own teeth; they are named for that thing. **The Red Fang** is older than the Hollow.

And that is why the arts never took. There was something enormous asleep behind Stabby's ribs, pushing back against every form they poured into him. **He was never unteachable. He was occupied.**

The Vigil on Kettlecrown

Nokk knew one more thing: where the Fourth had learned to seal what cannot be killed. A mountain called Kettlecrown, and a sect on it called the Sunward Vigil.

The Vigil are frog-folk, bullywugs grown enormous with age, and they cared about exactly one thing, and they tested it on his first morning. They asked him to be **still**: not sitting quietly, which he could have faked, but still all the way through, from the inside, in the moment before violence.

He failed for three months. He nearly left twice.

And then in the third month, in the dark, he finally heard the thing Master Kaelon Windstep had said to him years ago: *when the whole world is screaming, little storm, get still.*

He had always heard it as an order to calm down, but it was something smaller and far more useful:

be still for one second, at the one moment that matters. And one second was a thing Stabby could do.



The entire test is holding still.

The Forge

The sword came last, because among the Vigil a **Nichirin blade** is a graduation, not a gift. He worked the bellows for eight days of its making, and when it was done the masters put it in his hands and did not say congratulations, because the blade was the congratulations.

It is the dark, quiet sword on his back right now. It cuts corruption out of a living thing without cutting the living thing itself, and learning to do that one thing is what took him the year.



Eight days at the bellows before the steel ever met his hands.

Home in Winter



The woods the Bloodfang stopped walking in two years ago.

He came home in deep winter and did what he had promised: he went into the twisted woods and burned the blight out of the ground, root and all.

The Bloodfang had watched their biggest and best taken one after another for two years, and the thing that finally walked out of those woods with the blight dead behind it was **the runt**: the clan joke, the one they had all quietly agreed was not worth teaching.

There is not a goblin in the Hollow who will hear a word against him now.

Teaching the Count

Before he left, he lined up the smallest goblins in the Hollow, the overlooked ones, the ones he used to be, and taught them the count: one second of stillness, at the one moment that matters. It had taken the masters of Kettlecrown a year to get it into him, and he turned out, to everyone's surprise including his own, to be a wonderful teacher.



The first class in Bloodfang history where nobody is measured against anybody.

They offered him his father's seat and **he said not yet**, and Nokk was the only one who noticed he did not say never. He gave them Candyfang as the clan's heirloom, and by their new law the heirloom is carried by whoever the clan would follow, which is why it is still on his belt: it is theirs now, and he is only wearing it.

Stabby sits back down, upside-down grin firmly in place.
"Anyway," he says. "I got a sword."

Ursa Tells It: The Road East

The fire has burned low by the time it is Ursa's turn, and he does not stand up. He sets both hands flat on the table, with the stone he carries between them, and for a moment he just looks at it.

"The two of you went home," he says. "I went the other way."

► **Hand Ursa's player the floor, and slow the room down.** This is the chapter that changes the shape of the campaign. Read it last, read it quietly, and do not rush the ending.

He went first to the Circle, to old Selarin, and asked for his father's papers.

"You are eight," Selarin said.

"I know how old I am," said Ursa.

They argued for nine days, in the patient way druids argue, which mostly looks like silence. On the ninth day the old man unlocked the cabinet and handed over Ash Catchum's field notes without a word. Then he said one thing, which Ursa has repeated to nobody until tonight: *your father read the sky better than any of us. It did not save him. Read the ground too.*



Selarin knew from the first hour that he would unlock it.

The notes are the working papers of a man in the middle of a thought. Sky charts with dates. The same constellation drawn eleven times over eleven months, one point of light fainter in each drawing. And one word, underlined twice and never explained: **Betelgeuse**. The first star to go out.

The notes stop in the middle of a page, partway through a sentence.

The Skyless Country

He went east on foot and **alone**, because Ghostbloom stayed at the Guild and where he was going had no roads. Eleven months of walking.

When the maps ran out he came into a country where the cloud never breaks. No sun, no stars, no shadows to steer by. For a druid who navigates by constellations it was a blindfold, and he lost twelve days in there, and he still will not talk about them.

What saved him was that his father had been there first. **A road of cairns**, each placed exactly at the edge of sight of the last, so a person could cross the blind land one stone at a time. Ash built it going out. Ursa walked it going in, and **repaired every fallen one on the way**, because there was no reason to assume he would be the last person to need the road.



The Skyless Country has no horizon; it has the next cairn instead.

The Camp

He did not find his father. He found the camp his father made.

A firepit long cold. A shelter of bent living branches, still holding. Split wood stacked ready under cover, and a kettle still hanging from its tripod with rain in it. Nothing was packed and nothing was buried. **Nobody had said goodbye to this place.**

He stayed the first night without touching any of it, because moving so much as the cup felt like interrupting somebody. The shelter's doorway faced back along the cairn road, the way you face a door when you are expecting company.

And he found out how long the camp had stood empty by doing exactly what Selarin told him: he read the ground. The shelter was still alive and still growing, and the wood had closed over its bindings by an amount a druid can read like a page. The fire ring told it plainest: moss takes a stone slowly, at a pace the Circle teaches you to count, and the moss on those stones had three years' reach and not one season more.

The camp had not stood empty for nine years. It had stood empty for **three**.



The tin cup is still where a hand last set it down.

The Half-Carved Stone

Under the flat rock by the firepit, wrapped in oilcloth, was a river stone carved with Elaria's seven-pointed star. **Half of it.** The line stops mid-stroke, the way a pen stops when somebody says your name. It is his father's hand. When Ursa closed his fingers around it, the stone was warm. It has been warm ever since. He sets it on the dinner table now, and everyone understands at once that this is the stone he has been turning over since the Eastern Gate.



The one thing in the whole camp his father thought to protect.

The Eighth Night

He stayed at the old shrine eight nights. On the eighth, the cloud broke, the standing stones lit from the inside, and **Elaria showed him three things.** The first was his father, **walking**, deliberately, toward a light that was going out. Ursa has carried one small ugly question since he was old enough to understand the word *disappeared*: did my father choose to leave me? The answer is yes, and the reason is the best

reason there has ever been. **Ash Catchum went east to save the stars.**

The second was a wall at the bottom of everything, with something hungry and patient pressing against the far side of it. He knew the name from the Circle's old verses before the vision finished giving it to him. **Maldrith.**

The third was a shadow that walks for her, on a high place with the sky dying behind it, putting out a light as calmly as a person pinching a candle. And the vision gave that one a name too.

Nyxthid.



The old shrine has been waiting a long time for somebody to keep an eighth night.

► **This is the first time the name Nyxthid is spoken in this campaign.** Ursa has just sworn to hunt his own father and will spend four sessions doing it. Elaria did not lie to him: every single thing she showed him is true. She simply did not show him that the man walking east and the shadow in black are the same person. **Keep the figure featureless.** No face, no build, nothing that can be matched later. If a player asks what it looked like, it looked like a hole in the shape of a person.

"I swore to hunt it," Ursa says. "The shadow. Whatever it is."
He picks the stone back up and closes his hand around it.

Nobody speaks. The fire is down to embers, and out past the shutters the great city has gone quiet, and tomorrow the ring opens.

It is Lickgloom who ends it, by falling asleep face-first in the butter.

The Handover

► **One line to read off Stabby's sheet while it is in his hands**, because three fights tonight hang on it. **Cleansing Edge:** once per turn, when Stabby hits something corrupted with the Nichirin, the cut burns clean, and that target **cannot regain hit points until the start of his next turn**.

Three stories told, and one day left before the door opens.



Puff supervised the polishing, and she will tell you so.

Lilly has been awake since four in the morning. When the rest of you come down to the workshop the lamps are already lit, and there are four cloths laid out along the bench: one for each of you, and a fourth at the end for **Puff**, the small clay homunculus Lilly built and woke up herself. Puff is sitting beside her own cloth with her hands folded, plainly very proud, and she has been sitting that way for some time.

Lilly has a speech prepared. You can tell, because she gets about six words into it, gives up, and just starts handing things over.

► **Hand out the new character sheets here**, so the fiction and the paperwork land in the same beat. Six magic items arrive on three players at once and none of them works like a sword, so teach the traps now, in a quiet room, rather than on the far side of the ring.

WHAT LILLY BUILT DURING THE YEAR

Sorted by whose cloth it is sitting on

Wraps of Unarmed Power +2 (Stabby). No attunement, nothing to activate. +2 to hit and damage on every punch and kick, and they may deal Force.

Wand of the War Mage +2 (Ursa). While he is **holding** it, every spell attack gains +2 and he ignores Half Cover. Starry Wisp, his Guiding Bolts and the star-arrow all go to +10.

Wand of Web (Lilly). 7 charges, 1 to cast Web at the wand's own **DC 13**.

Ring of Spell Storing (Puff). Holds 5 levels of spells and casts them at the original caster's DC and slot; it arrives empty until somebody casts into it.

Wand of Magic Missiles (Puff). 7 charges: 1 for three darts that never miss, 1d4+1 force each, 120 ft. Up to 3 charges for five darts.

Pipes of Haunting (Puff). 3 charges. Magic action: every creature she chooses within 30 ft. makes a DC 15 Wisdom save or is Frightened for a minute.

► **Puff has one action**, so she uses only one of her three items per turn. And **wands recharge at dawn, not on a rest**, which matters on the far side of a portal where nobody knows how time runs.

The Briefing



The professor brought diagrams. Vane brought objections. Lickgloom found something to chew.

After supper Aelwyn clears the long table, pins up a map of nothing anyone has ever mapped, and gives you the truth in his lecture voice, which is the kindest voice he owns.

► **One.** The rifts are not doors somebody opened; they are tears, and everything strange the party has fought for two years came through one. **Two.** You cannot sew a tear from this side: you go to the other

side and bring back the plane's **Mote**, the torn piece of its heart the rift knocked loose; where it has lodged, nobody can know from this side. **Three.** The Sphere is the anchor and the way home, and **if it is lost over there, they do not come back.** Say that once, plainly, and never repeat it. **Four.** Every Mote returned wakes a little more of the Sphere. **Five.** Something living may come back with them, and Aelwyn is carefully vague, because he is guessing.

"I want you to understand that I am not sending you somewhere dangerous," Aelwyn says. "I am sending you somewhere *indifferent*. A plane is not hostile to you any more than a mountain is hostile to you. It simply does not care whether you can breathe there. Everything that hurts you on the other side will hurt you the way weather does."

Vane snorts. "That is a terrible speech."

"It is an honest one."

The Lesson: Underroot, and the Thing That Lives There

"Earth," says Aelwyn, "is not a cave. Get that out of your heads right now. You are not going underground. You are going to a place that is *made* of ground, all the way through, in every direction, forever.

"It is called Underroot. There is no sun there, and there has never needed to be one. There are roots down there the size of cathedrals. They are alive, and they are older than your species. The soil breathes, slowly, about once a minute, everywhere at once. And nothing down there is in a hurry, which will be the strangest part for you three."



He has waited his whole career to give this lecture, and it shows.

► **Three facts the players need for Part Two.** It is **slow, not empty**: a rockfall there is a shrug. There is **no sky, so Ursa cannot navigate**, and his year of star-reading buys him nothing; what works down there is reading the ground, exactly as Selarin told him. And it is **indifferent, not hostile**.

"Every world keeps something. Not a king, and not a god. A *guardian*: one creature, very old, that is somehow the shape of that world's health. When Gearhaven was sick you found the Grand Custodian at the heart of it, twisted almost past recognition, and when you freed it the whole city knitted shut behind you. Do you remember?"

He taps the board. "You did not do that by being clever. You did it by being *kind* to something that was hurting. I would like you to notice that, because you are about to do it again, and the thing you do it to this time is roughly the size of a hill."

"What if it fights us?" says Stabby, delighted.

"Then I would prefer you not *lose*."

► The Guardian of Underroot is **Groudon**, and the whole session is walking toward him. Aelwyn does not know his name and neither should the party: let them meet him as a shape in the dark and a sound in their teeth long before he is ever a stat block.

The Threshold

► Last beats before the crossing, in this order. **Ursa looks up** through the clerestory windows and sees that Antares is dimming, and says nothing; do not spend that, it pays off at the end of the night. **The idol goes cold** again in Stabby's pack, hard enough that he notices. **Lilly sets the Sphere in the cradle** and the brass takes it the way it did on the sixth night, without a hair of resistance. And **Vane does not make a speech**: he had ten years to write one, and what he actually does is put a hand on Lilly's shoulder for a second and then go and stand at the lever.

► **The rules of the road, before anyone crosses.** Four things shape everything on the far side, and the players should feel all four without being lectured. **There are no long rests in Underroot**: the run is one push, and the only real breather is the short rest after the Chime Reef, so spend accordingly. **Time is not free**: the ring holds, but every hour over there is an hour Vane stands at the lever holding his breath, so keep the token moving and let the pace be felt. **The goal is the guardian**: free it from its corruption and this world's cracks close on their own; nothing in Underroot needs to die for the party to win. And **the Sphere gathers the whole way**: loose planar essence flows into it wherever they walk, and everything it gathers comes home with them at the end of the night.

The ring does not roar.

The Sphere settles into its cradle with one small brass click, and the air inside the circle simply stops being air. On the other side there is a red-brown dark, and warmth, and a smell like a garden turned over after rain, and a sound so low you feel it in your teeth instead of hearing it.

Somewhere out in that dark, something the size of a hill breathes in.

Ghostbloom goes first, because of course she does.

Part Two: Underroot

One brass ring, four stops on a living road, and a country that has been waiting two years for help.



The first doorway between worlds ever opened on purpose.

► **The rift run is played on the Underroot board.** The board rules, the eight road events of the road between, and a printable two-page board all live in the appendix: read them once before tonight. In the chapter itself, the story pauses wherever the token lands.

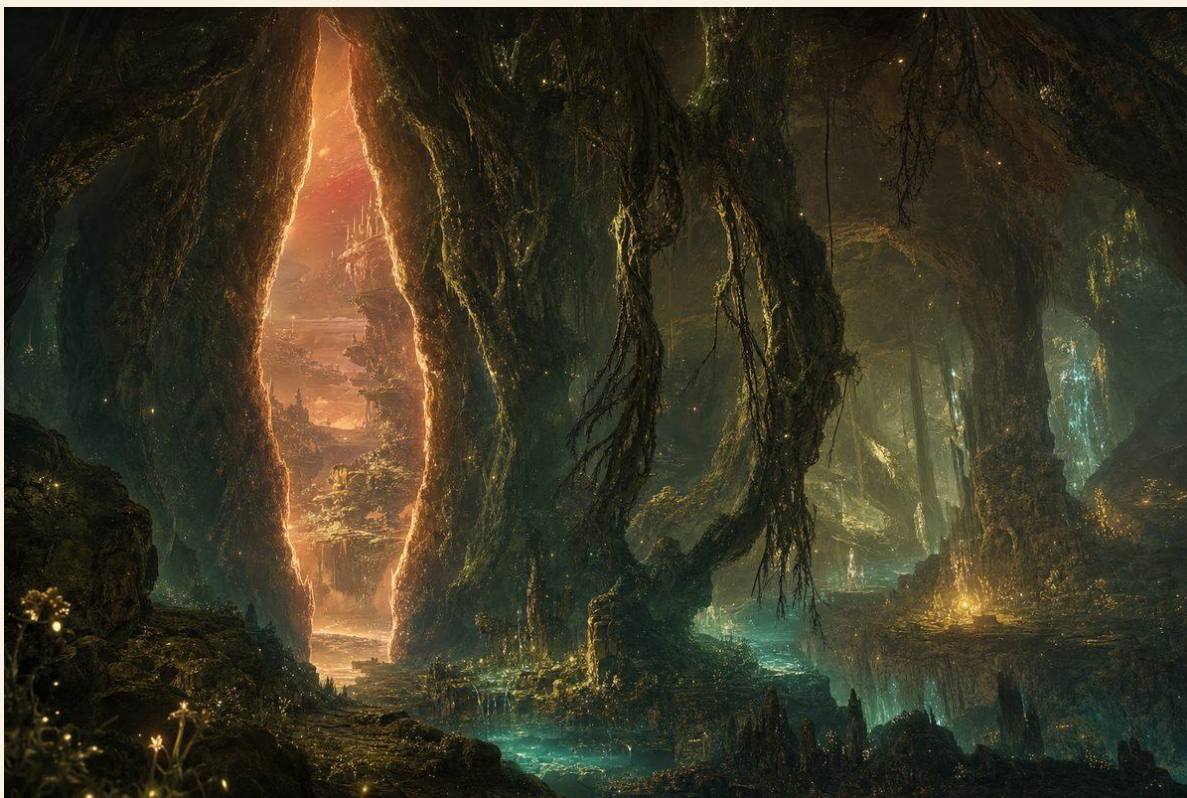
The Rift Gate: The First Breath

You expected a cave.

You are standing inside a root. One root, arched over you like the ceiling of a great hall, running away into the dark in both directions farther than your light can follow. The ground is warm under your boots, and soft, and it is breathing: a slow rise and settle, about once every minute, so gentle you have to stand still to be sure of it.

There is no sky down here, and no sun, but there is light anyway, a low green-gold glow coming off the moss in patches, enough to see by, and the smell that came through the ring is everywhere now: turned earth after rain, warm, with no other air behind it.

Behind you the ring hangs open, a bright coin of Gearhaven lamplight. Vane's shape is standing in it with his arms folded.



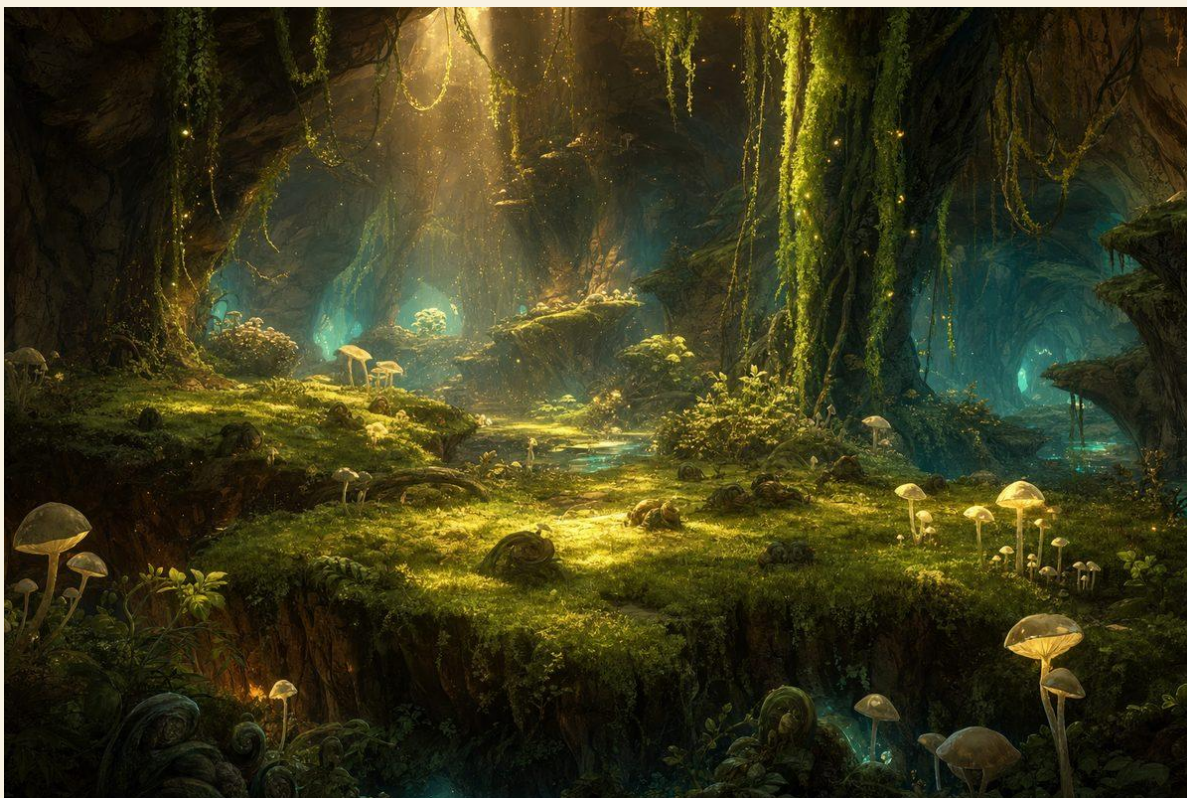
Vane watched them out of sight, and then a while longer.

► **Four beats to land here, one per hero and one for Ghostbloom. The Sphere is warm** in Lilly's hands, and it is *pulling*: she can feel it gathering, it has never done that before, and it does not stop for the rest of the session. **Ursa cannot navigate**, and say that to his player directly: no sky, no stars, and a year of star-reading buys him nothing. What does work is what Selarin told him, reading the ground, so give him **advantage on Survival** down here for root growth and soil. **Stabby's idol is cold**, colder than it was in the Rift Hall; he will keep checking it all session and it will keep getting worse. **Ghostbloom is delighted**, because she is a plant-spirit standing inside a plane made of growing things, and she has never been so happy. Let her chime read as joy all session, right up until the Hollow.

► **No encounter here.** This is the one safe scene where they simply get to be amazed, so give it all the room it wants.

1. Mosslight Landing: The Friendly Face

The walk from the ring is the first walking any of you have done in another world. The ground gives a little under every step, warm as the flank of something asleep. The moss brightens ahead of you and dims behind, so the road opens one patch at a time and is quietly put away again once you have used it. Ghostbloom rides at head height with every petal spread, chiming to herself. Nothing hurries you, nothing follows, and after an hour that stops feeling like luck and starts feeling like being noticed by something too big to be interested yet.



The only place in Underroot that will seem glad to see them.

Then the root opens into a hollow the size of a village, and it is beautiful. Round mossy mounds rise out of the floor, each with a little round door of packed earth, though nobody built them and nobody lives in them; that is simply the shape moss grows in here. Threads of pale gold light drift up from the ground like slow sparks going the wrong way. Something is watching you from the top of the nearest mound. It is about the size of a badger, armoured in overlapping plates of yellow-brown hide, with small dark eyes and two enormous digging claws, and it is holding as still as it can manage, which is not very still at all. It is trembling with the effort. One claw is still buried in the mound mid-dig, at an angle nothing would choose to stand at, and when Stabby waves at it, it does not wave back, because rocks do not wave. It has decided to be a rock until this crisis passes. Here is the strange part: nothing about it makes a hand go to a weapon. It is not corrupted; you are all certain of that at once, without knowing why. It is just small, and you are new, and it got here first.

► **The Sandshrew.** Unless a moss dot sends it back to dig them a shortcut, this is the only time they meet it in the flesh before the homecoming. It cannot be caught, tamed, or bagged. If they are kind to it or feed it, it follows at a distance for the rest of the run and is present at the end; if they are aggressive, it vanishes and joins them at the homecoming anyway. Ursa's Mark of Handling works on it, and that should be the moment his player realises the plane's wildlife is not the enemy.

You could stay an hour in this place. The mounds are warm to lean against, and the gold threads rise slowly enough to pick one and follow it all the way up into the dark. It is Ghostbloom who notices. Her chime changes in the middle of a note, the way a voice changes when it sees something over your shoulder, and she goes very still in the air, pointing with her whole body at the far side of the hollow. The pretty part of Underroot has a wound in it. On the far mounds the moss is grey and wet and wrong, and standing in the grey, swaying, are eight little flower-creatures. They were

lovely a month ago. You can still see it: round soft bodies, stubby arms, big round flower-caps that used to be gold. The caps are grey now, and slack, and they leak. When they notice you they all turn at once, and their faces are still smiling, because their faces cannot do anything else.

► **Offer these if the table wants lines:**

Ursa: "Look at the ground behind them. The flowers aren't the enemy. The grey is."

Stabby: "They're still smiling. Why are they still smiling?"

Lilly: "Cannon out. If we can't cure it, we can stop it walking."

► **Before initiative.** The Rotblooms do not charge; they come on at a sway, slow as weather, leaking as they walk, and the grey spreads a hand's width behind them wherever they linger. Give the table a round of looking: some heroes will strike at once, some will try to talk to the smiling faces, and somebody may work out that the flowers are not attacking, they are spreading. This cannot be talked down, and left alone the grey takes the whole landing, but the party should walk into their first fight in Underroot knowing the enemy is the grey, never the flower wearing it. The moment the first cap is struck, the ground boils: Mossmites pour out of the mounds in a wave, and Ghostbloom makes a sound nobody has ever heard her make, because they are almost the same as her. Roll initiative.



The grey is the enemy. Everything else is defending its home.

► **Battlefield.** A village-sized hollow of warm mounds and rising gold threads, with the grey holding the far rim. The mounds are cover and high ground; the grey creeps a hand's width wherever a Rotbloom lingers, so the longer this runs, the more of the map is theirs.

► **The pressure.** Eight Mossmites, fast and cheap, swarming boots and climbing packs while the real problem re-blooms behind them. Spore Puff keeps the whole party rolling saves, so nobody stands still and everybody gets three or four rounds of swinging.

► **The lever.** Rotblooms re-bloom every round, and ordinary steel keeps handing back ground it already won: leave one standing and part of that cap swells shut before its next turn. Only radiant damage or Cleansing Edge makes a cut stay. **Ursa's starlight is one answer and he will find it**

fast: when his first bolt sticks, tell him why. **Cleansing Edge is the other, and the only one that works up close.** Let Lilly watch her cannon's work close up again, then let Stabby ignite, cut one at the root, and have it stay cut. Hand him the first melee kill, and say the reason out loud when it lands: he spent a year on a mountain learning to burn corruption out of the ground, and this is the first time anyone else has seen it work. His player has carried that backstory alone since the telling.

► **Companions.** Puff and Ghostbloom are in the mix; Ghostbloom fights like it hurts, because these are almost her. The Sandshrew hides, and there is a tell for anyone watching closely: the Rotblooms do not attack it and it does not run from them. It is hiding from the party. Corruption does not eat its own.

► **Describe cues.** First clean kill: the grey wrings out of the cap like muddy water from cloth, one breath of gold, a sigh like a child finally put to bed, and where it lay the grey does not come back. The mite wave: the whole floor boils up to defend its flowers. A re-bloom: a wound in a cap swells shut while they watch. The Sandshrew: still being a rock, but a rock that is watching everything.

► **Scaling dials.** Too easy: the mounds keep spending Mossmites, a fresh handful each round until the last cap falls. Too hard: a struck Rotbloom spends its next turn re-blooming instead of walking, and the mites go for boots, not skin.

It is over faster than it felt. The last of the mites pour back into their mounds like water finding its level, and the landing goes quiet, and then, patch by patch, the ground where the grey was cut away begins to light again: one faint thread of gold, then a slow scatter of them, rising past your faces the wrong way, exactly as before.

The Sandshrew is back on its mound, at a careful distance, up on its hind legs. It is not pretending to be a rock anymore. It watched all of it, and it is watching you now the way you would watch somebody who just did a thing you did not know could be done.

Ghostbloom settles on Ursa's shoulder and stays there, ringing very softly, the same note the little flower sighed on.

The road out of the hollow climbs, and the air sliding down it to meet you is warmer than the air behind, and somewhere up ahead, very faintly, something rings.

2. Chime Reef: The Beautiful Trap

The road out of the Landing runs uphill, and Underroot changes as you climb. The moss thins first, its glow guttering out until your own lamps are doing most of the work. Then the soil changes under it: drier, firmer, with a fine glitter worked all through it. Lilly stops and lifts a pinch to the light and finds tiny broken chips of crystal, blue and gold, more of them with every hundred feet, as though somewhere ahead something enormous were shedding.

Then comes the sound, except it is not a sound yet. It is a pressure, low and sweet, somewhere underneath hearing, rising through the soles of your boots, and it grows with every step until you are leaning into it the way you lean into warmth.



A thousand years of patient growing, and none of it for visitors.

The tunnel opens and you all stop at once, because the sound arrives before the sight does. Crystals. Thousands of them, growing up out of a shallow black pool in spires and fans and thickets, blue and gold and green, some of them taller than Vane's workshop. And the whole reef is ringing, very quietly, one slow shifting chord you feel in your back teeth. When the ground breathes, the note changes.

Ghostbloom lifts off Ursa's shoulder and hangs in the middle of all that ringing with every petal spread. She is a spirit made of chime, and nothing has ever once answered her. She rings one small clear note out into the crystal, and the whole reef rings it back.

It is the kind of sound that loosens a grip without asking.

► **Three beats before the boulders stand up. Loud carries:** anything loud makes the crystals ring louder, and a big enough noise brings a spire down, so reward the player who works that out and uses it. **Lilly can read the growth pattern** with a **DC 13** Arcana check: the crystals are growing *toward* something deeper in, the way plants grow toward light, and the whole reef is leaning on whatever that is. (It is Groudon.) **And there is a quiet gift here.** If anyone spends a turn simply listening, Elaria's presence is faintly in the chord; Ursa's player may notice it is the same seven-pointed shape as the star on his father's stone.

The reef has been answering you the whole way in, and none of you noticed, because the answers were beautiful.

Every footfall comes back off the crystal, tiny and bright. Lilly's pack clinks and a spire clinks back. Somebody laughs and the reef hums the shape of it half a second later. And the deeper you go, the more of the chord leans toward you, note after note bending in your direction, until the truth lands all at once: you are the loudest, warmest, fastest-moving thing this reef has ever held, and you have been ringing its doorbell with every single step.

The chord drops. It goes low, and flat, and wide awake. The moss light dims in one slow pulse, and out in the pool the ripples stop.

Four boulders in the shallows unfold legs and stand up.

They are squat and heavy and armoured in deep blue-black rock, with blunt jaws and small bright amber eyes, and jagged orange crystals grow out of their backs and shoulders like a struck chord frozen in place. Nothing about them is rotten or grey or wrong. They are heavy as loaded carts, and they are between you and the deep.

Then the air is full of wings: pale crystal darts the size of hawks dropping out of the spires, banking once, and coming down at you fast enough to whistle.

► **These are not corrupted.** The Chimestones are the reef's immune system, and the party is loud and warm and came in through a hole. They cannot be talked down: the reef has already decided. Play them as weather with legs; nothing in this fight is sick and nothing is cruel, and that matters at the end.

► **Roll initiative. Offer these if the table wants lines:**

Lilly (eyes on the crystal): "They ring when we're loud. Fine. Let's find out what a *real* noise does."

Stabby (blade low): "Nothing's wrong with these ones. They're just big, and we're the strangers."

Ursa (steady): "The reef is guarding something. Break only what we have to."



Every note in the cavern is now about you.

► **Battlefield.** A shallow black pool ringed with crystal spires, fans, and thickets: the spires are cover, and they are also bells. Four Chimestones stand between the party and the tunnel to the deep, slow and heavy and hard to move; four Shardwings dive from the high spires and spit shards from sixty feet, so nobody gets to stand still.

► **The pressure.** This is a real fight. AC 16, heavy hits, and the reef rings a little louder every round; keep describing the sound climbing until everybody's ears hurt. The Chimestones come on like a slow wall, and the Shardwings punish anyone who stands still or bunches up.

► **The lever.** Thunder. Any thunder damage **stuns a Chimestone until the end of its next turn**, and it takes **double damage** from every source while stunned. Lilly's Boomstick blast is thunder, and so are her Thunderwave and Shatter and Ursa's Thunderwave; the Shardwings are **vulnerable to**

thunder as well, so one discovery wins the whole encounter. (Stabby's Nichirin is steel and force, not thunder: the reef does not ring for him, and this one belongs to the casters.)

► **The spire.** Anyone can spend an action to strike a big spire (**DC 13 Athletics**): the note rolls out and every Chimestone within **30 ft.** makes a **DC 14 Constitution save** or is stunned as above. The striker is standing inside the bell and takes **1d6 thunder** for it, which keeps the trick honest. Let them bring the roof down on the last one if they earn it.

► **Companions.** Ghostbloom is torn, and it shows: she hangs high over the pool through the whole fight, ringing with the reef even while it fights her friends. Puff's magic missiles do not care how fast a Shardwing dives.

► **Describe cues.** First thunder hit: the boom goes into the Chimestone and does not come back out; it locks mid-stride, ringing itself apart, and every spire in the cavern takes up the note. A felled spire: it goes over like a tree made of glass and does not crash, it tolls, one ring you can watch cross the black water and feel through the breastbone. A Shardwing dive: fast enough to whistle, shards chiming where they hit stone. A stunned Chimestone destroyed: it comes apart all at once, like a chord ending.

► **The stand-down.** The fight can end without the last kill, and it is better if it does. When the last Chimestone is stunned, or the win is no longer in doubt, put one beat of quiet on the table before anybody rolls again. If the party lowers their weapons and backs out of the shallows, the reef stands down: no check, no cost, it simply works, because an immune system does not chase what is already leaving. Do not offer this. Let a player think of it, exactly as with Thumpaw, and pay the idea in full when they do. If they finish the last one anyway, the fight was honest and nobody gets scolded; the chord is simply one note smaller on the way out, and Ghostbloom hears it. Read the exit below only if they step back; if they cleared the shallows, let the ringing come down slowly on its own and go straight to the rest.

► **Scaling dials.** Too easy: two more Shardwings drop out of the high spires on round 3. Too hard: one Chimestone breaks off to plant itself in the tunnel mouth, guarding instead of fighting, and the party faces three.

You step back, and the reef notices.

The last Chimestone stands in the shallows with its amber eyes on you, ringing softly, and does not follow. Then, joint by heavy joint, it folds its legs back under itself and settles into the water, and it is a boulder again, and you would swear it had never been anything else. Around you the ringing comes down slowly, wild harmonics settling back into the old patient chord, the moss light steadying, the pool remembering how to ripple. The reef has decided you are weather: loud, strange, but the kind that passes.

You take your rest inside a chord.

There has never been a stranger campsite, and there may never be a better one. You eat sitting on warm stone with music coming up through it, the reef's slow ringing folded around you like a roof, and the notes change when the ground breathes, so the whole meal happens inside something enormous and calm that is almost a song. Ghostbloom hums along, quietly, the entire time, and nobody asks her to stop.

► **SHORT REST, right here.** Take it the moment the last Chimestone goes quiet, and say so at the table: Hit Dice spent, Stabby's Focus back, Ursa's Wild Shape back, Lilly's Aether Ward back. The Glassed Gallery is built assuming they walk in full, and it is not kind if they do not.

3. The Glassed Gallery: The Wound

You know something is wrong a hundred feet before you reach it, because the ground stops breathing.

Ahead of you the roots are **black glass**. Not burned: glassed, smooth and shining and hard, frozen in the middle of reaching for something. The whole gallery is silent in a way nothing else down here has been; there is no moss light, and your own lamps look small in it.

And every surface, when you get close, is covered in fine cracks that are very slowly, very quietly, spreading.



Black glass from wall to wall, and the shine of it is the worst part.

► **Let them feel the size of it.** This is not a monster's lair; it is a burn scar spreading outward at the speed of grass growing, and it has been at it for two years. Nothing here needs a check to understand. The cracks all radiate from one direction, deeper in, toward the Hollow, and any hero who looks at them for ten seconds can say so out loud.

Stabby's idol has stopped being merely cold. It aches in the palm now, cold the way a nail left out in winter is cold, and after a minute of carrying it he has to wrap it in a fold of cloth and put it away. It has never once behaved like this.

► **Explain nothing.** No check identifies it, no NPC has a theory, and nothing down here reacts to it. It got colder near the ring and it is colder still here; that is the entire beat. Let his player sit with it.

The Sphere is brighter here than it has been anywhere in Underroot, bright enough that Lilly is holding it a little away from her body, and it is drinking hardest exactly where the glass is thickest. Whatever is bleeding out of this wound, her Sphere was built to gather it.

► **Give Lilly that deduction free,** no roll. It is the first hard evidence for the theory she spent her year building: the Sphere grows by going out into the world, and a wound this size is a feast.

And then, from deeper in, past where the moss light died, you hear it: glass on glass, soft and patient and perfectly regular, like somebody sweeping a floor that will never come clean. It has been going a long time, and it does not stop when you come closer.

► **Let them approach the sound as slowly as they like.** It is the Weeper, still at its work, and it pays them no attention at all until light finds it. There is no ambush waiting in this gallery, only a job that never ends, so heroes who scout get the full reveal below before anything moves.

The Glass Weeper

Something is still standing in the gallery.

It has the shape of one of the big slow root-tenders, a long neck, a crown of fronds for combing the roots clean, but it is far too tall to be one. It is black glass grown into the memory of a tender, built up around something at its centre you cannot see, and the glass moves the way a hand moves a puppet. And the puppet is **still trying to do the job**: sweeping shattered glass fronds through glassed roots that cannot feel it, over and over, patiently, forever.

Around its feet, rolling in fast, are lumps of black glassy coal the size of ripe pumpkins, each with one furious orange eye.



The Gallery's keeper, as the corruption remembers it.

It does not notice you until your light touches it. Then the sweeping stops.

The long neck comes around. The crown of broken fronds opens like a black glass fan, and from somewhere deep inside the mimicry a thin note begins to rise, and every crack in the gallery sings along with it. The tenders of Underroot were made to clean their roots of anything that does not belong, and the thing wearing this one's shape has just decided that what does not belong is you.

► **Roll initiative the moment the light touches it.** Offer these if the table wants lines:

Stabby: "It's still trying to do its chores. Then I'll finish them for it."

Lilly: "Watch the cracks, they're closing! Plain hits are going to pour right back out of that thing."

Ursa: "The roots under the glass aren't dead. Something in there is still holding on."



Rolling coal, keening glass, and the hardest fight on the road down.

► **Battlefield.** The Weeper is rooted at the heart of the gallery and never leaves its roots; it does not chase, and it does not have to, because it reaches fifteen feet and hits three times a turn. That gives the fight its shape: step into its reach and take the frond hits, or hang back and deal with what comes rolling out of the dark.

► **The pressure.** This one is meant to be hard. The Cinderolls arrive two at a time, never all four at once, rolling twenty feet and detonating, so the pressure never stops and never quite swamps the party. Popping one next to its friends is a chain reaction; let the players work that out themselves and enjoy it. The Keening is the scary button (30-ft cone, DC 15 Constitution, 21 psychic and frightened), and it is at its meanest landing on the same turn a fresh pair rolls in.

► **The lever.** Two of them, and the table should find both. Steel: the Weeper regains **10 hit points at the start of its turn** unless it took radiant or force damage, or was hit by **Cleansing Edge**, since its last turn, so with ordinary weapons every wound they open is part closed again before their next turn and the fight reads as if it is going backwards. **Stabby is the answer, and everyone at the table should be able to see it.** Kindness: any hero can spend an action tending the glassed roots the Weeper is bound to (**DC 14 Nature or Medicine**, or any healing spell cast on the roots instead of a creature). On a success the Weeper **loses its regeneration until the end of its next turn** and every attack against it has **advantage** until the start of the helper's next turn. Two or three of those and the fight tips hard; it never ends the encounter, it makes the party feel brilliant while they finish it. The first tend is the heart of the whole session, so let the room go quiet before you describe what it does.

► **Companions.** Puff's Wand of Magic Missiles is force damage and never misses, so on a turn when Stabby cannot reach the Weeper, her missiles are the other way to hold its wounds open. Ghostbloom wants nothing to do with this creature; keep her at the edge of the light unless a hero calls her in.

► **Describe cues.** The first hit that sticks: where the burning edge or the missile lands, the glass greys and the wound stays open. The Keening: when it wails, every crack in the gallery sings along. The tend: warmth under the hands, the glass clouding over and letting go, one finger's width of living green, and across the gallery the Weeper stops mid-sweep and leans toward it the way a tired thing leans toward a

fire. The chain pop: pop, pop, POP, festival crackers in the dark, and for one second the gallery is lit gold; the fight has earned exactly one laugh, and it lives here.

► **Scaling dials.** Too easy: the second pair of Cinderolls arrives a round early. Too hard: pull the fourth Cinderoll if the table is on the ropes.

When it finally falls it does not crumple. It **shatters**, all at once, a whole creature's worth of black glass coming apart across the floor with a noise like a window breaking in another room. And in the middle of the wreckage, curled up small where its heart should have been, is an ordinary little animal. Grey fur. Four paws. It has been dead for two years, and something built a statue around it and kept it working.

► **This is where the session stops being an adventure and becomes a rescue**, and it is the last beat before Groudon. One quiet image, nothing gruesome and no lingering, then silence at the table, and let a player be the one who speaks first.

Afterward, Stabby walks out into the gallery alone. He lights his breath, and sets the burning edge against the black glass.

► **Stop there and hand the narration to Stabby's player.** This image is the whole point of his year, so let him be the one who says what the glass does. No check, no cost, no roll. If he stalls, offer him the picture and let him carry it from there: where the Nichirin passes, the black glass **flinches**, greys, dulls, and crumbles back into ordinary soil, exactly the way the blight recoiled from him on the mountain at home. The path stays clean behind them.

He cannot heal a place a mile wide, not alone and not tonight. What he can do is burn one clean path straight through the middle of it, and that is the road you walk out on.

You are not fifty steps along that road when Ursa stops walking, and then all of you hear it. Behind you, faint as a sleeper turning over, at the very edge of feeling, the ground along the clean path has begun to breathe again: one narrow road's width of Underroot, remembering how. Nobody says anything for a while, and it is a good kind of quiet.

Past the wound the tunnel narrows, then steepens, then simply ends, and everything they have felt underfoot all day turns out to have had a source.

4. Groudon's Hollow: The Guardian

The tunnel ends at a ledge, and past the ledge there is no floor. Your light goes out into the dark and does not come back with a far side.

Something down there is breathing.

You have felt it all day, the slow rise and fall of the ground under your boots, once a minute, everywhere you went. You thought that was just how this plane was. Standing on this ledge, you finally understand what you have been walking on top of since the gate.

It was never the plane breathing.

It was **him**.



The bottom of the world, where every road in Underroot has been leading.



The Continent-Maker. The glowing seams are his own. The black glass is not.

He fills the hollow the way a mountain fills a valley. His plates are red-brown and bigger than barn doors, his claws are sunk deep into stone he has not moved from in a very long time, and seams of magma glow along his flanks like banked coals.

Driven into his back, up near the shoulder where no claw of his can reach, is a **spike of black glass**. Every crack in this world runs outward from that one point.

He is the reason there is dry land anywhere. He has been in pain for two years, and in all that time he has not been able to tell a single living soul.



Everything in this room is enormous except the thing that matters.

► **The frame.** Groudon is not the villain; the spike is. This is Gearhaven's Grand Custodian rule at ten times the scale: free the guardian and the cracks close. If the players do not reach for that on their own, say it out loud at the table, because the whole encounter is built on it. Nobody is killing a god tonight.

► **Offer these if the table wants lines:**

Ursa (after touching the Mark): "He's not angry. He's hurting. He's been trying to say one word for two years."

Stabby: "Hold on, big guy. This is going to feel a lot better in a minute."

Lilly: "Puff, the wand! Glass can't dodge magic missiles. Nothing can!"

Running the Fight

► **Battlefield.** The hollow floor, lit by his own magma seams. Groudon barely moves from his spot; he is the terrain. The spike rides his back near the shoulder, and reaching it means climbing him (**DC 14** Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics), one check to reach the shoulder; Thrash is the separate check to stay on), flying (Stabby's Sash), or a called shot at range with disadvantage.

► **The pressure.** Groudon has **AC 18 and 230 hit points** and hits hard enough to drop a level-7 hero in two turns; a straight brawl is a loss, and it is supposed to be. Play him as a natural disaster with a wounded animal inside it, never a tactician: he does not aim, focus fire, or plan. Alternate **Continental Step** (he moves, the floor changes, DC 16 Dexterity within 30 ft of his path or knocked

prone for 11 bludgeoning), **Magma Vent** (recharge 4-6, a 60-ft line 10 ft wide, DC 17 Dexterity, 35 fire, half on a success), and **Claw** (+12 to hit, reach 15 ft, 24 slashing) if anything is in reach. **Thrash** whenever the spike takes damage (once a round, no action): every creature climbing him makes a DC 15 Strength or Acrobatics check or falls for 3d6. And **Agony**, while the spike is intact: at the start of each of his turns he takes 10 damage himself, and everything within 20 ft makes a DC 16 Dexterity save or takes 10 bludgeoning from the shockwave. He is being hurt in front of them, every round, and they can see it.

► **The lever.** The win condition is the spike, never his hit points: **AC 17, 60 hit points, immune to everything except radiant, force, and Cleansing Edge.** At the start of each of Groudon's turns it **re-knits 20 hit points** unless Cleansing Edge has touched it since his last turn; range can wound the glass, but only Stabby makes the wound stick, on the same rule the Rotblooms taught at the landing. **When the spike breaks, the encounter ends instantly**, whatever Groudon's total is. Never run him to 0. He is not supposed to die, and nothing in this room is an execution.

► **Glasslings.** The spike drops one at the start of each of Groudon's turns: a cat-sized scuttler of black glass that goes straight for the nearest warm body and bursts when killed (**DC 12 Dexterity, 5 slashing, 5 ft**). They answer the obvious question, why not whittle him down from range: the longer the spike lives, the more little glass things are chewing on the party.

► **The rescue.** If Ursa reaches out with the Mark the way Selarin taught him, he finds no rage in there at all: only pain, old and patient, and underneath it something that has been trying to say *help* for two years with no mouth to say it with. Only Ursa can feel this, and telling the others is the moment the fight becomes a rescue; hand his player the discovery and let him be the one who tells the table. If nobody reaches for the Mark, the Agony scream carries the same news.

► **He does not finish them.** If a hero drops, Groudon immediately moves away. He never finishes anyone; he does not really know they are there. He is swatting at pain, not hunting children. Say that out loud the first time it happens.

► **Jobs.** Stabby ends this, and the whole session has been building to it: speed 65 with his breath lit, Step of the Wind to close, and a Nichirin that is one of only three things in this world that can touch the spike at all. Do not let anybody else take the last blow unless his player hands it over; if the dice go badly, Ursa's summon can pin Groudon in place or Lilly's Flash of Genius can rescue the climb check so the strike is still his. Ursa keeps everyone standing, drops a summon between Groudon and whoever is climbing, and is the only one who can feel that the creature is in pain. Lilly shoots the spike from range (rule it a valid target for Puff's wand: it is the corruption's heart, not furniture) and holds the party together with Aether Ward.

► **Companions.** Puff's Wand of Magic Missiles is force damage and never misses; it hits the spike, and all of it sticks as long as Stabby keeps the burn on the glass.

► **Describe cues.** The first hand on his hide: heat like a hearthstone hours after the fire, and a heartbeat rolling up through the palms. The first Agony shockwave: he screams, and it is his own spike doing it to him. The first Glassling: it drops off his back already running. A climb through Thrash: plates shifting underfoot like a hillside deciding to move.

► **The pause.** When the last hit is about to land on the spike, stop the table before the roll and give it one breath: a bright hairline through the black glass, the magma seams dimming to embers, the Glasslings freezing where they stand, the mountain holding himself still as if something in him, deeper down than two years of pain, knows what is coming. Then let them swing. When it breaks, every Glassling on the board collapses into ordinary sand at once; clear them off the map in one sweep of your hand and say nothing while you do it.

► **Scaling dials.** Too easy: the spike drops two Glasslings a round instead of one. Too hard: Magma Vent stops recharging while anyone is on his back, and Thrash telegraphs (his plates bunch a beat before he shakes, advantage on the check).

► **If it all goes wrong.** Nobody dies in this room. If all three heroes drop, Groudon stops swatting the moment nothing is stinging him, the Glasslings herd rather than bite, and Vane, watching the thread of

the ring from the lamplight side, hauls everyone back through. They wake at the ring having lost, hurting and whole, and the spike is still there for another day.

The Way Home

When the Spike Breaks

The black glass does not shatter.

It comes apart all at once and quietly, like a held breath let go, into a spray of dark motes that hang in the air for a single heartbeat and then rush, every one of them together, into the Sphere in Lilly's hands.

And Groudon goes absolutely still. Then he lowers himself onto his belly on the stone with a sound like a hillside settling, and he breathes out, and the breath goes on so long that somebody laughs once out of pure nerves, and every root in the hollow shivers along its whole enormous length.

Then he turns his head, slowly, and looks at the three of you properly for the first time.

There is no anger left in him at all, only a tiredness so deep you can feel it from where you stand.



The first thing he has felt in two years that is not pain.

► **Slow down.** Everything after the spike is the part they will remember: not the end of a fight, but the end of two years of somebody's pain.

► **The encounter ends the instant the spike drops, whatever his hit points are.** Do not roll another attack, do not finish the round, do not let anybody get one more hit in. And **every Glassling on the board collapses into ordinary sand where it stands**, mid-lunge, mid-bite, all of them at

once. Clear the miniatures off the table with your hands while the players are still watching; the sound of them coming off the board will say more than any description could.

As the last of the glass leaves him, something else comes loose from the wound in his shoulder. It is a fist-sized ember of packed red-brown light, dense as a river stone and warm as fresh bread, and it does not fall. It drifts across the hollow, unhurried, and settles against the Sphere like an animal finding the right place to sleep.

This is the **Mote of Terra**: the piece of this world's heart that was caught here, come home to the only thing in the room built to carry it.

Groudon gathers himself, and the floor of the world moves with him. He reaches out one claw, a claw that has moved continents, and sets the very tip of it on the ground in front of **Ursa**, with a care that would not crack an egg.

You do not need any magic to understand what he means by it.

Then he begins to walk. Where he walks, the cracks close behind him like a seam pulled shut, and far off in the dark you can hear the glassed gallery crumbling back into plain, ordinary, breathing soil.

► **Give Ursa the line if his player wants it.** He is the only one who can feel what the creature is feeling, and what it is feeling is *relief*. Let him say it out loud to the other two, in his own words. Coming from a player instead of from you, that sentence will land twice as hard.

► **The road home is a montage, not a board run.** The country walks them out: passages open ahead of them, the dots stay dark, and if the Ceiling ever shut the way, it stands open now. Groudon walks with them as far as the reef. Ten minutes of glory, and not one die is rolled.

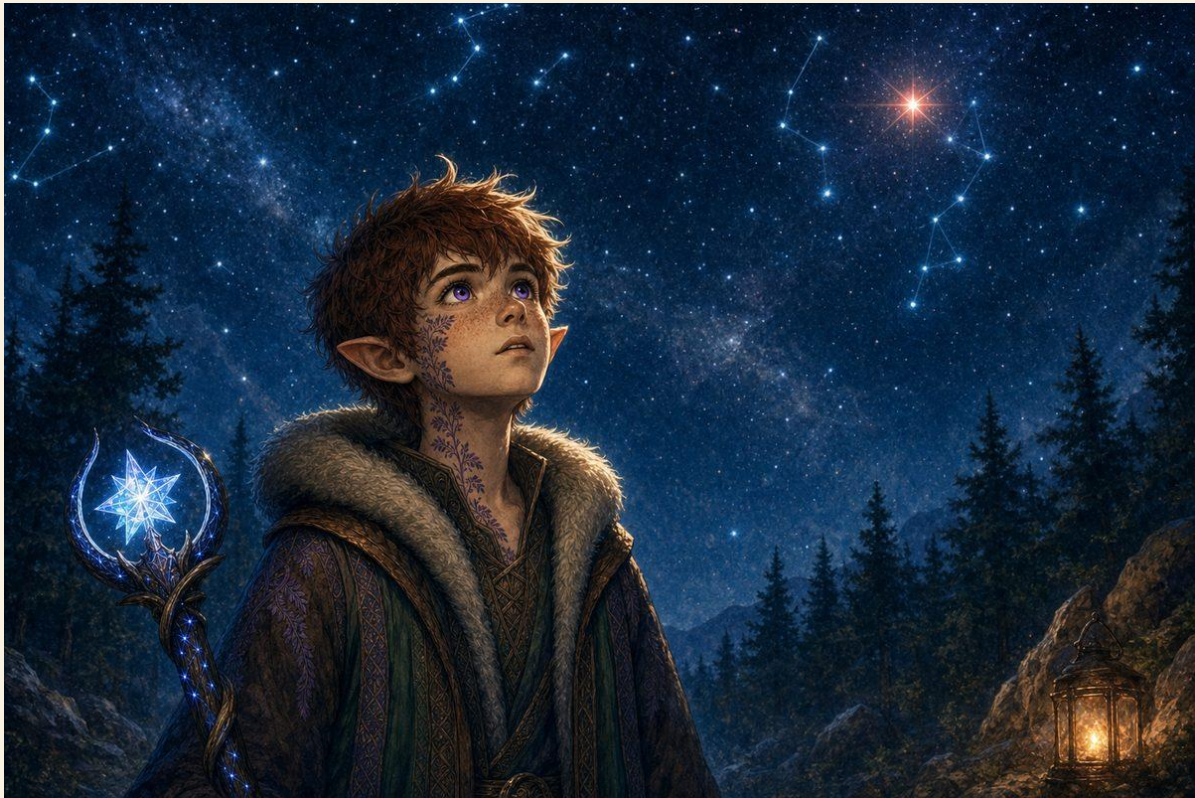
Antares

You come out of the ring into lamplight and noise, with Vane shouting three questions at once, and it is a long few minutes before anybody thinks to look up.

Ursa does.

Through the clerestory windows of the Rift Hall, over the wet slate roofs of Gearhaven, there is the star he watched fading on the night they all left, and tonight it is the deep, steady red it is supposed to be, the red it is in every one of his father's charts. His father spent a year drawing that star getting fainter, month after month, and then he put the pen down and walked east to do something about it. In all the watching since, nobody has ever seen a star come back.

This one has.



The eastern sky over Gearhaven, carrying news only one person in the city can read.

► **Only Ursa understands what he is looking at.** He watched Antares dim on the night they left and said nothing to anybody; he has spent a year with those charts. Let his player be the one to explain it to the others, in his own words, at his own speed. Then let **Aelwyn** go very quiet, because a man who has been arguing a theory for thirty years has just watched it become a fact.

► **The Staff of Waking Constellations answers.** One new star kindles on the haft and stays lit. This is the job the staff was built to do, and tonight is the first time anyone has seen it work.

The Sphere Will Not Settle

The Sphere has been getting brighter since Underroot, and now it is too bright to look at straight. It is warm as a stove top. It hums against Lilly's palms hard enough to make her teeth ache.

Aelwyn takes one look at it and tells everybody to stand back, and for once he is not delighted. He is **nervous**, which is worse.

"It gathered more than it can hold," he says. "It only keeps one shape at a time."

"So what happens?" says Lilly.

"It is going to have to choose."



One steps into the light as the other steps out: the first swap.

Ghostbloom chooses first.

Nobody asks her to; nobody even gets the chance. She drifts around in front of Lilly so the two of them are eye to eye, and she chimes once, the small clear note she has been making since a foggy path above the sea two years ago.

Then she steps into the light and is gone.

The Sphere goes calm in Lilly's hands, and the room is very quiet.

► **Play this straight and let it hurt for three or four seconds.** The kids will think they have just lost her. They have not: she is the tether, she is perfectly fine, she is aware in there and she can come back out tonight. Aelwyn explains all of that in a moment. Do not rush to reassure them before the moment lands, and do not stretch it past four seconds either. Count it in your head.

And then the light in Lilly's hands stands up.

The gathered essence of a whole plane pulls itself into a shape, and what steps out of the glow, blinking in the lamplight and thoroughly unimpressed with all of you, is the small armoured digger from Mossflight Landing. Yellow-brown plates. Enormous claws. Very much solid, very much real. He shakes himself the way a dog does, and a little Underroot soil scatters across Vane's clean workshop floor.

► **Where he goes matters.** If the party was kind to him at Mossflight Landing, or fed him, he walks straight to whoever did it. If they were unkind, he crosses the room to **Ursa** and settles against his boot, and on the way he goes right past the hero who chased him off without once looking up. **Then say nothing.** No explanation, no consolation line, and do not let Aelwyn talk over the silence; the table will work out what just happened on its own.

"The Sphere gathers," Aelwyn says, crouching down to be polite about it. "That is all it has ever done. Today it gathered an entire world's worth of loose essence, and essence gathers toward warmth, and toward company. So it brought somebody home."

► **Teach the companion-swap rule right here, before anybody goes home.** The full script, in the words to say it, is in the run sheet appendix under **The Companion Swap**. Teach it, then hand Sandshrew over and let them run the first swap themselves, right there in the workshop, so Ghostbloom steps back out where they can all see her.

REWARDS: WHAT UNDERROOT GAVE THEM

The concrete gains, once the shouting in the Rift Hall dies down

Sandshrew. A companion, freely given, gathered out of the essence of a whole plane. He digs, he takes a hit, and he is made of the same stuff as the ground he stands on. **Second on the roster, and the first proof that the roster is real.**

Ghostbloom, the Tether. Unharmed and unchanged, riding inside the Sphere as its anchor and stepping back out **One companion out in the world at a time**, everybody else riding inside; the swap is Lilly's Action.

The Mote of Terra. The torn piece of Underroot's heart, pulled from the guardian's wound and socketed into the Sphere. **The rift is closed**, properly and for good, sealed by a guardian walking home.

Tectonic Slam. Lilly's **first Elemental Discharge**, woken by the Mote of Terra. Four sockets in the Sphere stay dark, and she can feel every one of them.

A New Star on the Staff. Antares is lit. One new star kindles on the haft of the Staff of Waking Constellations and stays lit.

What Each of Them Carries Home

Lilly gets the thing she spent a year arguing for: proof. Her power grows by going out, exactly as she worked it out alone at a bench in Gearhaven, and now there is a Mote in a socket and a discharge in her hands that nobody built for her.



Sandshrew, with somebody else's dirt still on his claws.

Late that night Lilly has the Sphere open on the workbench, the Mote sitting in its new socket, and she is not looking at anybody.

"It isn't full. That's the thing. There's a whole *plane* in there and it barely moved the needle." She turns it over in her hands. "I can feel where the other four go. The sockets are there, and they're empty, and when I put my hand flat on it I can almost hear what it would sound like with all five."

"I don't think it's a battery. I think it's an instrument. And I've only ever played one note on it."

► **What that plants:** her ceiling is very high and entirely gated on rifts cleared. She has gone from one discharge to a promise of five in a single night, and she is the only one who can feel how much bigger this gets. Give her player a quiet moment with it.

Ursa carries home a relit star and the first hard evidence anybody has ever had that the damage can be *undone*. He also carries the beginning of a private worry, and he does not share it: the spike did

not grow in Groudon's back. Somebody made it and drove it in deliberately. And he brought a name back from a shrine on a mountain.

Stabby carries a katana that did something no other blade in the world could do, and one small fact he is keeping to himself: the idol went cold when they stepped through the ring, colder still in the glassed gallery, and it warmed the instant they came back through. He noticed exactly when it happened.

Threads to Leave Hanging

► **One: who drove the spike in?** Nobody says a name at the table tonight, and neither do you. But the party has now seen with their own eyes that the rifts are not weather: somebody is causing them.
Two: the idol. Cold at the threshold, colder at the gallery, warm at home. Where that thread finally goes is still yours to decide; until you decide it, explain nothing and promise nothing.
Three: four stars to go, and two of them are still bright. Aelwyn will work out what that means before the next session is over: if the lights are being put out one by one, then somewhere out there is a star nobody has reached yet, and the party can get there **first**.

It is very late. Vane has finally stopped talking. Sandshrew has fallen asleep in a crate of brass fittings, and nobody has the heart to move him.

Aelwyn stands at the high window with his hands behind his back, looking east, at a star that spent two years dying and is not dying anymore.

He says it to nobody at all.

"One."

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ The Second List

The Circle has kept its list of stars for forty generations, and in all that time the scribes have only ever done one thing to it: cross names out. There is no mark in their book for a name coming back, because nobody ever needed one. The eldest sky-reader alive was asked, once, what the Circle would do if a dark star ever relit. She thought about it for a long while. Then she said: begin a second list.

APPENDIX

The DM's Run Sheet

Every DC, dial, and spotlight, in play order. Keep this page at your elbow.

The Shape of the Session

► **PART ONE is read, not rolled.** Seven days early: Lilly alone in the Rift Hall, Vane too loud and sleeping too little, and the cradle that does not quite fit until the sixth night, when it does → THE PROFESSOR: Aelwyn Ravenstone, three trunks, no help, and Lickgloom recognising the party (the only uncomplicated happy reunion all night) → DAWN AT THE EASTERN GATE: Ursa on foot, taller and quieter, turning a stone over in his left hand → TEN TO MIDNIGHT: Stabby off the rail without a sound, and **the idol knocks against the flagstones cold enough to burn** → THE THREE CHAPTERS, read in full, in this order: Lilly (the most hopeful), Stabby (the loudest), Ursa (NYXTHID, and it changes the campaign, so it goes last) → THE HANDOVER: hand out the level 7 sheets here, teach the traps in a quiet room → THE BRIEFING: five facts, and say the one about losing the Sphere exactly once → THE LESSON: slow, no sky, indifferent, and free the guardian → THE THRESHOLD.

PART TWO is played on the Underroot board. The party moves as ONE token: a player rolls **1d6**, moves that many spaces, and the token passes to the next kid on the next roll. The colour they land on resolves at once, and **the die they just moved with picks the outcome: even or odd.** No table to look up, no second roll. The four numbered locations are not dots: the token stops at each one whatever movement is left, the beat plays, and movement resumes next turn. THE RIFT GATE (arrival, no fight, one safe scene to be amazed) → MOSSLIGHT LANDING and the Sandshrew (**FIGHT 1**) → CHIME REEF (**FIGHT 2**) → **SHORT REST, immediately after the reef, called out loud** → THE GLASSED GALLERY (**FIGHT 3**), and the small creature curled inside the glass that turns the adventure into a rescue → GROUDON'S HOLLOW (**BOSS**): the spike breaks, the Mote of Terra comes home → back through the ring, and Ursa looks up at Antares → THE HOMECOMING: Ghostbloom steps into the Sphere, Sandshrew steps out, the swap rule gets taught, and Aelwyn says one word to nobody.

The natural break point is the Threshold. Part One ends the moment the air inside the ring stops being air; if the evening has to stop somewhere, stop it there and start the next one on the far side. Inside Part Two the second-best pause is the short rest after the reef. **Pace check:** there are 19 dots between the gate and the Hollow, and they are texture, not the session. If the night is running long, hand-wave the dots between the Gallery and the Hollow and go straight to Groudon. Never let a garnet dot swell into a fifth big fight.

RUNS ALL SESSION. The Sphere is pulling, warm in Lilly's hands from the first breath of Underroot, and it does not stop; it drinks fastest where the damage is worst. **Ursa cannot navigate:** no sky, no stars, and his year of star-reading buys him nothing, so give him advantage on Survival for reading root growth and soil, exactly as Selarin told him. **The idol gets colder the deeper they go,** and you never explain it. **Ghostbloom is delighted,** a plant-spirit inside a plane made of growing things, right up until the Hollow. And **none of the four scripted fights can be talked down, waited out, or avoided** (the road's creatures are another matter, and finding that out is the players' reward): the levers below turn grinding fights into satisfying ones, they are never an off-ramp.

Fights at a Glance

FIGHT 1: Mosslight Landing (warm-up, but it runs long; it teaches the session's rule). 8x Rotbloom (AC 12, HP 33; **Re-Bloom**: it regains 5 HP at the start of its turn if it took damage and is not at 0; Cap Slam +3 for 2d4+1; Spore Puff, recharge 5-6, a 10-ft cone, DC 12 Constitution or 2d6 poison and poisoned) + 8x Mossmite (AC 13, HP 7, Speed 40 ft and climb 40 ft; Skitter, no opportunity attacks; Pack Nerve; Nip +5 for 1d4+3), boiling out of the moss the moment the first Rotbloom is struck. **THE LEVER: Cleansing Edge**. A Rotbloom cannot re-bloom if it has taken radiant damage (Ursa's starlight) or been hit by Cleansing Edge (Stabby, up close) since its last turn. Let Lilly watch her damage undo itself, let Ursa's first bolt stick, then hand Stabby the melee kill and have it **stay** cut. **The tell**: the Rotblooms do not attack the Sandshrew and it does not run from them. Corruption does not eat its own.

FIGHT 2: Chime Reef (hard on paper, easy the moment somebody thinks of thunder). 4x Chimestone (AC 16, HP 78, **VULNERABLE THUNDER**, tremorsense 60 ft; Multiattack two Crystal Rams at +6 for 2d6+4; Shard Volley +6 for 2d8 at 40 ft) + 4x Shardwing (AC 14, HP 33, fly 50 ft, **VULNERABLE THUNDER**; Dive +6 for 2d6+2, plus 1d6 more if it came 30 ft straight in; Shard Spit +6 for 1d10+2 at 60 ft). **THE LEVER: Resonant Body**. Any thunder damage **stuns a Chimestone until the end of its next turn, and it takes DOUBLE damage from every source while stunned**. Thunderwave and Shatter turn a wall into a free kill. Better still, anyone can spend an action striking a big spire (**DC 13 Athletics**): every Chimestone within 30 ft makes a **DC 14 Constitution save** or is stunned the same way, and the striker takes 1d6 thunder for standing that close. Nobody minds. Lilly's **DC 13** Arcana read: the crystals are growing toward something deeper in. It is Groudon.

FIGHT 3: The Glassed Gallery (the hardest thing before the boss, and Stabby's proving ground). 1x Glass Weeper (AC 16, HP 170; **Glassbound**: regains 10 HP at the start of its turn unless it took radiant or force damage, or was hit by Cleansing Edge, since its last turn; Rooted, it never leaves its glassed roots by more than 15 ft; Multiattack three Frond Lashes at +7 for 2d6+5 with 15 ft of reach; Keening, recharge 5-6, a 30-ft cone, DC 15 Constitution for 6d6 psychic and frightened) + 4x Cinderoll (AC 15, HP 18, Speed 40 ft rolling, **arriving two at a time**; Rolling Charge adds 1d6 and a DC 12 Strength save or prone; **Burst** at 0 HP, DC 12 Dexterity within 10 ft or 2d6 fire; Slam +4 for 2d4+2 plus 1d6 fire). **THE LEVER: Tend the Roots**. An action clearing or healing the glassed roots (**DC 14 Nature or Medicine**, or any healing spell aimed at the roots rather than a creature) strips Glassbound until the end of the Weeper's next turn and gives everyone **advantage** on attacks against it until the start of the helper's next turn. Two or three of those and the fight tips hard. Let the kids chain a Cinderoll off its neighbours; that is what packs of them are for.

BOSS: Groudon's Hollow (the rescue, not the kill). Groudon (AC 18, HP 230, tremorsense 120 ft, CR 11; **Continental Step**: he moves, and everything on the ground within 30 ft of his path makes a **DC 16 Dexterity save** or takes 2d10 and is knocked prone; **Magma Vent**, recharge 4-6, a 60-ft line 10 ft wide, **DC 17 Dexterity** for 10d6 fire, half on a success; **Claw** +12 for 3d10+8 at 15 ft; **Agony**: while the spike is intact he takes 10 damage at the start of each of his turns and everything within 20 ft makes a **DC 16 Dexterity save** or takes 3d6 from the shockwave) + Glasslings (AC 14, HP 10; Glass Bite +5 for 1d6+3; Shatterburst at 0 HP, DC 12 Dexterity within 5 ft for 2d4), **one spawned at the start of each of Groudon's turns**. **THE LEVER IS THE ONLY WIN CONDITION: THE SPIKE**. AC 17, 60 hit points, immune to everything except **radiant, force, and Cleansing Edge**, reached by climbing, by flight, or by a ranged attack at disadvantage, and it **re-knits 20 HP at the start of each of Groudon's turns unless Cleansing Edge touched it since his last turn**. Damaging it triggers **Thrash** (once a round, no action): every climber makes a **DC 15 Strength or Acrobatics check** or falls for 3d6. **When the spike breaks the fight ends**

instantly, whatever his hit points are, and every Glassling on the board collapses into sand in the same heartbeat. Do not run him to 0. He is not supposed to die, and **He Does Not Finish Them**: a hero who drops is left alone, because he is swatting at pain, not hunting children.

THE ROAD BETWEEN (garnet dots only, small pressure, never a fifth big fight). **Even: Thumpaw** (1x, AC 14, HP 76; two Shovel Slams at +7 for 2d8+5; Immovable; Not Actually Angry, so it never starts it, never pursues, and never finishes a downed hero). A straight brawl with no gimmick, on purpose. Do not offer the way out; if they think of befriending it themselves, **DC 15 Animal Handling**, with advantage from Ursa's Mark, moves it aside. **Odd: the Gleamoth** (3x swarm, AC 12, HP 26, fly 40 ft hover, resist bludgeoning, piercing and slashing, **VULNERABLE FIRE AND THUNDER**; Smother +4 for 4d4, or 2d4 at half HP, and blinded until the end of its next turn). They chase the warmest, brightest thing in the tunnel, which is the Sphere, so the swarm sits on Lilly all fight and the party has to come to her. **The other dots, even then odd:** moss gives the Deepwater Spring (1 Hit Die back, one level of exhaustion cleared) or the Shortcut (advance the token 3 spaces free, and only if they were kind at the Landing); ochre gives Sinkloam (**DC 13 Strength** or restrained, heavy armour at disadvantage, so somebody has to go back for Lilly) or the Ceiling Lets Go (**DC 14 Dexterity**, 2d10 bludgeoning, half on a success, and the way back is shut); amethyst gives the Reef Answers (**2d8 temporary hit points** for everyone, and a fine place for the short rest if they have not taken it) or the Guardian's Dream (no mechanical effect, and Ursa may regain one spent omen).

The Resource Picture

► One evening, one long day underground, and **exactly one short rest inside it**: Call it by name at the table, because it is where **Hit Dice get spent** to heal, and three things come back on it: **Stabby's Focus** (7, and Igniting the Breath costs 1 while Devour refunds its own on a kill), **one of Ursa's three Wild Shape uses** (Starry Form spends one and runs 10 minutes), and **both of Lilly's Aether Wards** (2d8 + 5 temporary hit points to her and every friend within 30 ft, twice per short rest). The Reef Answers dot hands out 2d8 temporary hit points and the Deepwater Spring gives back a Hit Die and a level of exhaustion, so the road can quietly pay for a rough fight. What to watch: **Stabby's Focus across four fights plus whatever the dots throw**, because he is the answer to three of them and cannot afford to arrive at the spike empty; **Ursa's concentration**, one thing at a time, and his Wild Shape, since Starry Form and a summon are competing for the same three uses; **Lilly's Aether Ward**, which is the party's only pre-emptive shield and wants spending before Magma Vent, not after; and **Ghostbloom's Guardian's Light** (a reaction within 30 ft, 2d8 + 3 and it ends charmed or frightened, three times a short rest), which is the safety net for the whole run. She carries it all night and only steps into the Sphere at the very end, so nothing about it changes until the homecoming. **Run her triage-first**: Guardian's Light and guarding before the lash, damage only when nobody needs saving. Lilly's **Flash of Genius** (+5 to a failed check or save for her or a friend within 30 ft, five times a day) is the spare: hold at least one for the climb up Groudon's back.

Spotlights & Seeds: every kid shines, every door gets planted

Lilly: she is on the ground seven days early because she cannot stand waiting anywhere else → the cradle Vane built from a description closes around the real Sphere as though it were cut for it → her

chapter is the year of questions, ending on a workshop floor with the marks under the brass and the sentence that reframes everything: **her mother did not make it, her mother found it, and it is a gatherer** → the Handover is hers, six gifts on four cloths, five of them made for somebody else → in Underroot the Sphere pulls from the first breath and she is the only one who can say why → her Arcana at the reef reads the crystals leaning toward something deeper in → in the Gallery the Sphere is visibly drinking, and she works out that the loose essence bleeding out of this wound is exactly what it was built to collect → at the Hollow she is the ranged answer to the spike, and **force damage from Puff's Wand of Magic Missiles never misses it** → the Mote of Terra comes home and **Tectonic Slam wakes**. (Doors: four empty sockets and a ceiling gated entirely on rifts cleared; and somebody, a very long time ago, built the thing her mother only housed. Give her the workbench beat that night: it is not a battery, it is an instrument, and she has only ever played one note on it.)

Stabby: he arrives ten minutes early and pretends otherwise, and the idol hits the flagstones cold enough to burn → his chapter is the loudest in the book: **he was never unteachable, he was occupied**, the Fourth was his father, the Red Fang is older than the Hollow, and the whole test on Kettlecrown was holding still for one second → he came home and burned the blight out of the ground, and the clan that agreed he was not worth teaching offered him his father's seat, and he said not yet → **Fight 1 is built to hand him the session**: Cleansing Edge is the only thing at the table that makes a Rotbloom stay cut, and it is the first time anyone else has seen his year work. Say it out loud when it lands → **Fight 3 is his proving ground**: the Weeper claws back 10 a round, so every wound they open is part shut by the time it comes round to them again, and he is the reason it is winnable, and afterward let him walk the glassed roots with his breath lit and burn a clean road out of the wound for everyone else to walk → **the boss is his**: Speed 65 ignited, Step of the Wind to close, and the Nichirin is one of only three things in the world that can touch the spike. He climbs a mountain that is trying to shake him off and he cuts the corruption out of a god. Do not let anybody else take that unless his player hands it over; if the dice go badly, rescue the climb with Ursa's summon or Lilly's Flash of Genius so the last blow is still his. (Doors: the idol he has told nobody about, and a seat he did not say never to.)

Ursa: he comes in with the dawn traffic, taller and half a beat slower to answer, turning his father's half-carved stone over and over → his chapter goes last because it moves the campaign: the cairn road Ash built going out and Ursa repaired going in, the camp nobody said goodbye to, wood growth that reads **three years, not nine**, and a vision that gives him **Maldrith** and then hands him **Nyxthid** the way you hand somebody a weapon → at the Rift Gate, tell his player directly that the sky is gone and his year of star-reading buys him nothing down here, then give him advantage on Survival for reading the ground, which is what Selarin actually told him → the **Mark of Handling works on the Sandshrew**, and that should be the moment his player understands the plane's wildlife is not the enemy → he is the party's engine room all run: healing, control, and a summon between Groudou and whoever is climbing → and he is the only creature in the Hollow who can **feel that the guardian is in pain**. Telling the others is the moment the fight stops being a boss and becomes a rescue → afterward, in Gearhaven lamplight, he is the only one who looks up, and **Antares is the deep steady red it is supposed to be**, the first star in living memory to come back. One new star brightens on the Staff of Waking Constellations, which is exactly what it was made for. (Doors: a father who was alive three years ago, a name to hunt, and four stars still to go.)

Foreshadow Tracker: say it, then say it again

► The tells, in order, and every one of them pays later. **ANTARES:** Ursa looks up at the Threshold, sees it dimming, and says nothing (do not spend that beat); he looks up again on the way home and it is burning steady, and he is the only person alive who understands what that means. Aelwyn goes very quiet, because a theory just became a fact, and his last line of the night is one word: One. • **THE IDOL:** it hits the flagstones cold enough to burn when Stabby drops his pack, forty feet from a portal that is not even lit; it goes cold **again** at the Threshold, hard enough that he notices; it is colder still at the Rift Gate and painful enough in the Glassed Gallery that he wraps it in cloth to carry it; and it is **warm** the instant they come back through, and he notices exactly when, and tells nobody. Never explain it. • **NYXTHID**, named aloud for the first time in this campaign, in Ursa's vision, with **Maldrith** pressing behind the last wall. Keep the figure featureless: no face, no build, nothing anybody can match to a person later. If a player asks, it looked like a hole in the shape of a person. • **THE HALF-CARVED STONE:** Elaria's seven-pointed star in his father's hand, the line stopping mid-stroke the way a pen stops when somebody says your name, warm since the day he picked it up. • **PIKACHU AS A KEY:** the spark spoke in dread-images through the Mark in Gearhaven, of a vast hunger, a herald-shadow, and itself as *a key. To something*. Nobody has asked to what, and this session quietly proves the Sphere gathers whatever is loose, friend or scrap alike. • **THE GUILD-STAMPED CRATES:** the essence-harvest crates in the Dutchman's hold wore the Gearhaven Artificers' Guild seal and were bound south, and this whole session is spent standing in that Guild's own Underworks, being helped, by people nobody has thought to ask about it. Do not resolve it. Let one crate in the background of the Rift Hall carry the same stamp, and say nothing at all.

The Companion Swap: the rule, and the words to say it

► **Teach this properly and teach it tonight.** It is the mechanic the rest of the campaign runs on, and this is its first outing. Say it in this order, in these words, small enough for the youngest player to repeat back:

One out at a time. The Sphere holds one companion in the world. Everybody else rides inside it, safe and awake and perfectly fine.

Swapping is Lilly's Action. She calls the name, the one outside steps into the light, and the one she called steps out. "Sandshrew, I choose you!" That is the whole ritual, and yes, she should get to say it out loud.

Nobody ever dies in there. A companion knocked to **0 hit points faints**, the Sphere recalls it on the spot, and it is not lost, not hurt for keeps, not gone. Promise that once and never break it.

Choose before you go, not in the middle. Ghostbloom heals and senses planar things; Sandshrew digs and takes hits and is made of the same stuff as the ground. Picking wrong for a plane is a real mistake and an entirely survivable one, which is exactly what makes it an interesting decision.

► **When somebody calls for Pikachu, and somebody will:** the Sphere sparks, strains toward the name, and dims. He heard. He tried. Something still holds him, and the Sphere is not yet strong enough to pull him through. Let Aelwyn say the true thing, gently: "Not yet. But he heard you." Explain nothing further; that thread has its own night coming.

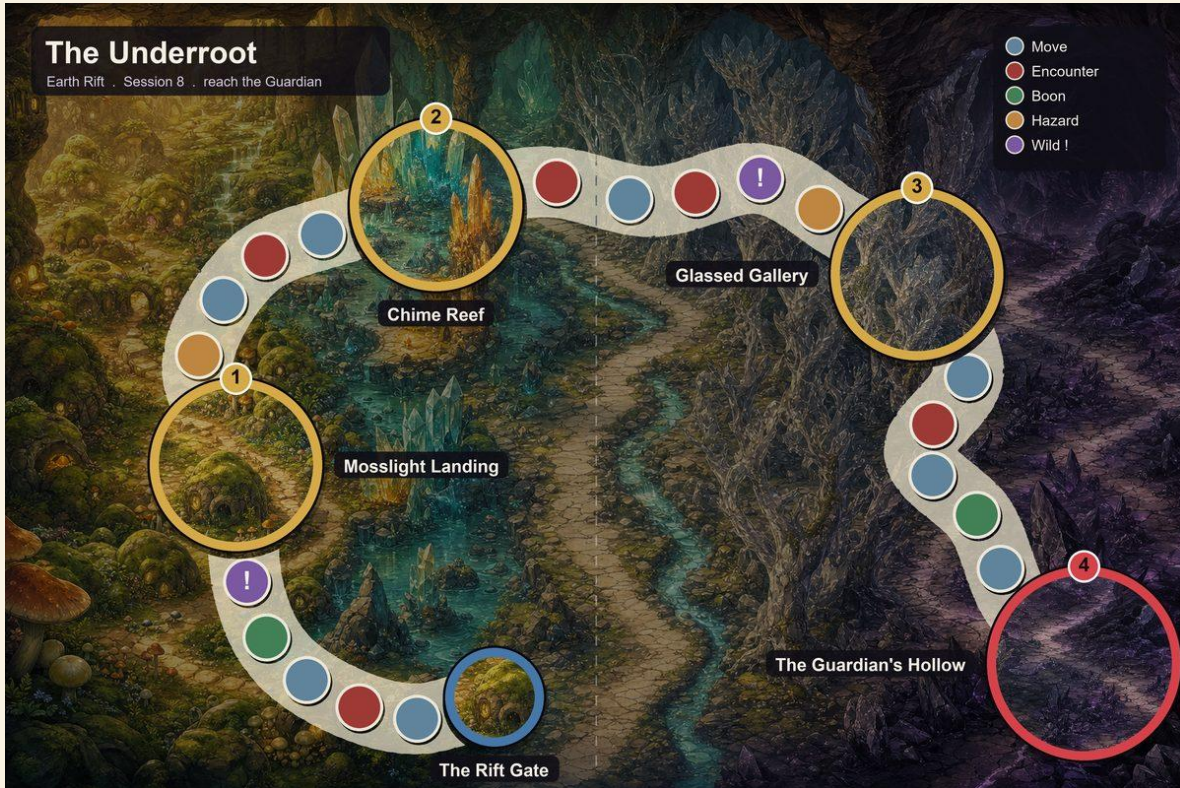
► **The roster grows by one per rift. Say that out loud tonight.** Four more planes, four more companions. The kids should start arguing about who they want next before the dishes are done, and they will be right to. Then hand Sandshrew over and **let them run the first swap themselves**, right there in the workshop, just to prove it works and get Ghostbloom back out where they can see her.

APPENDIX

The Underroot Board

The board, its rules, the road between the landings, and a printable two-page map.

How the Board Works



The whole country between the ring and the Guardian, laid out one landing at a time.

- **One token, everybody's hands.** The party moves as a single token. On their turn a player rolls **1d6** and moves that many spaces, and whoever holds the token rotates on every roll, so every player gets to move it. They land on a colour and it resolves at once.
- **The die they moved with resolves the dot.** Each colour has two outcomes, and even or odd picks which one happens: no table to look up, no second roll, no pause. Slate blue is plain movement and does nothing on either result. All eight outcomes are written out in full in *The Road Between*.
- **The four numbered locations are not dots.** They are fixed story stops. The token halts at each one no matter how much movement is left, the beat plays out, and movement resumes on the next turn. **The Rift Gate is the arrival and has no fight.**
- **They came here to fight.** None of the four scripted fights can be talked down, waited out, or avoided. Levers and objectives exist to turn a grinding fight into a satisfying one, never to skip it, and finding one is the reward.
- **SHORT REST, immediately after the reef.** Call it out loud so nobody misses it: Hit Dice spent, Stabby's Focus back, Ursa's Wild Shape back, Lilly's Aether Ward back. Fight 3 assumes they took it.
- **A note on the numbers.** Fights 2 and 3 sit deliberately above a "deadly" budget on paper, and both have a lever that collapses them: **thunder stuns a Chimestone and doubles all damage against it**, and **tending the roots strips the Weeper's regeneration**. A party that finds the lever wins comfortably. A party that ignores it is in a real fight. That gap is the fun, so do not soften either one before the players have had their chance to be clever.

The Road Between

Underroot is not empty between the landings, and the dark between them has its own weather.

The ground stays warm the whole way, and it goes on breathing under your boots, slow as something enormous asleep. There is no sky to measure your progress against, so the only way to know you are moving is the moss light going out behind you, patch by patch, as you leave it.

Twice, something big enough to hear keeps pace with you out in the dark for a while, and both times it falls behind without ever showing itself.

► **How a dot resolves.** Read the die they moved with. **Garnet** is an Encounter (even: Thumpaw; odd: the Gleamoth). **Moss** is a Boon (even: the Deepwater Spring; odd: the Shortcut). **Ochre** is a Hazard (even: Sinkloam; odd: the Ceiling Lets Go). **Amethyst** is Wild (even: the Reef Answers; odd: the Guardian's Dream). Slate blue is simply movement: nothing happens, keep going.

► **Garnet dots are small pressure, nothing more.** One patient boulder, or a cloud of hungry moths: a little cost, never a real fight. Never let a dot roll weak things that cost a little resource and no more. Never let a dot roll swell into a fifth big fight: the four scripted encounters are the session, and the dots are texture between them. Thumpaw and the Gleamoth appear nowhere else in Underroot, which is exactly what makes a garnet dot feel like luck instead of filler. Pace check: there are 19 dots between the gate and the Hollow, so if the evening is running long, hand-wave the dots between locations 3 and 4 and go straight to Groudon.

Thumpaw

A shape unfolds out of what you took for a boulder. It is the size of a cart horse, round and shaggy with matted brown moss growing over stone-grey hide, and it has hands like shovels. It looks at you with small patient eyes and does not move, because you are standing in the tunnel it was going to use.

► **Garnet dot, even. One Thumpaw.** It will not move, it is directly in the way, and when somebody inevitably prods it, it swings. This is a plain brawl on purpose: **76 hit points**, two big slams a turn, no gimmick and no puzzle, for the nights when a table just wants to hit something large until it stops. It never pursues and it never finishes a downed hero; it is grumpy, not evil. If the party genuinely tries to befriend it rather than fight it, **DC 15 Animal Handling**, with advantage from Ursa's Mark of Handling, will move it aside. Do not offer that. Let them think of it.



Thumpaw, the boulder that minds being prodded.

The Gleamoth

The lights come round the corner before the sound does: forty pale green sparks drifting like blown seeds. They are moths, each the size of a hand, and every one of them is glowing, and they want the warmest thing in the tunnel, which is you.

► **Garnet dot, odd. Three Gleamoth Swarms**, not corrupted, just hungry for heat. They **blind and smother** rather than deal much damage, and they go for whoever is carrying light. **Fire and thunder scatter them fast**, so anything that hits an area is worth double here. The real cost is the Sphere: they are drawn to it hardest, which puts the swarm on Lilly for the whole fight and makes the rest of the party come to her.



The Gleamoth, hungry for the warmest thing in the tunnel.

The Deepwater Spring

A crack in the wall, and inside it a pool so still and so clear that the pale stones forty feet down look close enough to lift out. Nothing feeds it, and nothing drains it, yet the surface keeps turning over, slow and patient, the way water moves when something a long way underneath it is still working. It is very cold, and it tastes like the air after lightning, and by the time you have all drunk, the ache has gone out of your legs and none of you can say when it left.

► **Moss dot, even.** Everyone regains **1 Hit Die** and clears **one level of exhaustion**. Ghostbloom glows brighter for an hour and is insufferable about it.

The Shortcut

Something small and yellow-brown is waiting for you on a mound in the middle of the path, up on its back legs, and it does not run when your light finds it. It looks at you. Then it looks,

very deliberately, at the blank wall on its left. Then back at you, and it keeps doing that until somebody understands. Then it drops and digs, and the packed earth goes soft in front of its claws like water, and the tunnel it opens runs straight and level and exactly the way you were trying to go. It is gone before any of you reach the far end. All it leaves behind is a scuffed patch of loose soil where it stood, and the distinct feeling of having been done a favour.

► **Moss dot, odd. Advance the token 3 spaces free**, and the space it lands on does not resolve: the shortcut is the whole gift. If the party was unkind to the Sandshrew at Mosslight Landing, it watches them take the long way round instead, and that should sting.



The Deepwater Spring: the pool keeps its own light.



The Shortcut: a door where there was wall.

Sinkloam

The floor stops being floor. There is no sound and no warning: one step is packed earth and the next is warm wet loam that takes your boot, then your shin, then your knee, and goes on politely taking. It is worst for the smallest of you: the loam does not care how clever anyone is, and whoever goes in deepest is suddenly fighting to keep their arms above the surface while the ground drinks the rest of them with terrible, unhurried patience.

► **Ochre dot, even.** Everyone makes a **DC 13 Strength save** or is **restrained**, spending an action to pull free. Heavy armour has disadvantage on the save. If Lilly goes under, she holds the Sphere over her head with both hands the entire time, and somebody has to go back for her.

The Ceiling Lets Go

You feel it before you hear it: a low grinding roll somewhere far above, the sound a mountain would make turning over in its sleep. Then dust comes down in fine threads. Then the threads become gravel. You have exactly long enough to look up and understand what is about to happen, and nowhere near long enough to be somewhere else, and then the ceiling of the world lets go.

When the roar stops and the air clears enough to breathe, the passage you came in by is not there. In its place is a wall of new stone, still warm, still shifting and settling against itself, and above you Underroot has already gone quiet again, as though it had shrugged in its sleep and thought nothing of it.

► **Ochre dot, odd. DC 14 Dexterity save, 2d10 bludgeoning** on a failure and half as much on a success. The passage behind them is now blocked, which matters a great deal if anyone was planning to run.



Sinkloam: patient, and wearing the colour of safe ground.



The Ceiling Lets Go: you can only be lucky.

The Reef Answers

Somewhere far off, a single crystal note. Then another underneath it, and another, until the whole tunnel is ringing in a slow enormous chord you can feel in your ribs, and the moss on the walls lights up in time with it.

► **Amethyst dot, even.** Everyone gains **2d8 temporary hit points**, and Ghostbloom sings back, badly, at the top of her voice. **This is a good place for the short rest** if the party has not taken it yet (and if they take it here, it IS the run's one rest; the post-reef stop becomes a breather, not a second one).

The Guardian's Dream

For half a second the three of you see the same thing, and Ghostbloom sees it too, and none of you asked for it.

An empty sea under an empty sky, going on forever. And something walking through it, huge and slow and patient, and where it walks the water shoulders aside and dry land comes up behind it, steaming, new.

Then it is gone and you are standing in a tunnel again.

► **Amethyst dot, odd. No mechanical effect.** They have just watched Groudon remember his own job, and they will not understand what they saw until they are standing in front of him. Ursa may **regain one spent Omen Dream**, because something has just spoken to him and he does not know what.



The Reef Answers: an invitation through a mile of stone.



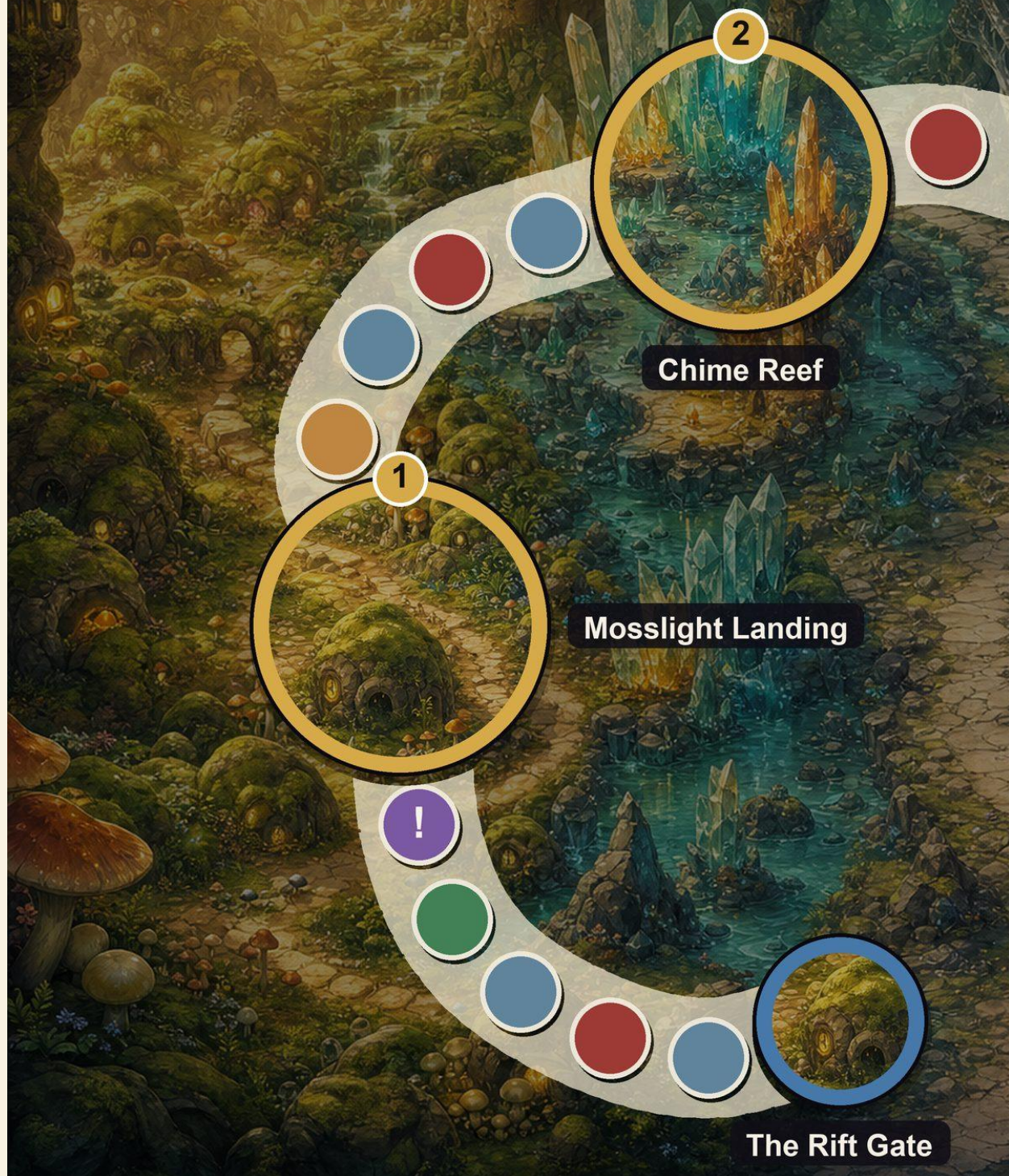
The Guardian's Dream: a memory that is not theirs.

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ **The Living Country**

The sky-readers teach that a plane is not a place but a creature: one living thing wearing a country for a body, with weather for moods and seasons for a pulse. Walk gently, the Circle says, for every step in another world is a step on somebody. The old verses go further still: each world keeps one guardian, very old, that is somehow the shape of that world's health, and to free a guardian is to heal the country it carries.

The Underroot

Earth Rift . Session 8 . reach the Guardian





APPENDIX

Bestiary: Enemy Stat Blocks

Every creature of Underroot, in the order the party meets them.

ENEMIES, Fight 1: Mosslight Landing

Mosslight Landing ♦ Difficulty: Warm-up ♦ 8x Rotbloom + 8x Mossmite

ROTBLOOM

Small plant (corrupted), unaligned ♦ CR 1/2 (100 XP) ♦ 8 in the grey moss



AC 12 **HP** 33 (6d6 + 12) **Speed** 25 ft
STR 10 **DEX** 12 **CON** 14 **INT** 4 **WIS** 8 **CHA** 6
Resist poison **Imm.** (cond) blinded, deafened, poisoned
Senses blindsight 30 ft, passive Perception 9
Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Traits

Re-Bloom. At the start of its turn, if it took damage since its last turn and is not at 0 HP, it regains 5 hit points. It cannot re-bloom if it has taken radiant damage, or been hit by Cleansing Edge, since its last turn.

Still Smiling. It cannot be frightened, and its face never changes, whatever is happening to it.

Actions

Cap Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (2d4 + 1) bludgeoning damage.

Spore Puff (Recharge 5-6). 10-ft cone, DC 12 Constitution save: 7 (2d6) poison damage and poisoned until the end of its next turn; half damage and no poisoning on a success.

MOSSMITE

Tiny beast (corrupted), unaligned ♦ CR 1/8 (25 XP) ♦ 8 boiling out of the moss



AC 13 **HP** 7 (2d4 + 2) **Speed** 40 ft, climb 40 ft
STR 6 **DEX** 16 **CON** 12 **INT** 2 **WIS** 10 **CHA** 4
Senses blindsight 30 ft, passive Perception 10
Challenge 1/8 (25 XP)

Traits

Skitter. It does not provoke opportunity attacks.

Pack Nerve. It has advantage on attacks against a creature if another Mossmite is within 5 ft of it.

Actions

Nip. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage.

Tactics: *This fight exists to hand Stabby the session. The Rotblooms swell back up out of their own caps every round, and ordinary steel keeps handing that ground back: only radiant damage or Cleansing Edge shuts Re-Bloom off. Let the party flail for a round and let Lilly and Ursa watch pieces of their damage close up again, then let Stabby ignite, cut one, and have it stay cut. The Mossmites boil out of the moss the moment the first Rotbloom is struck, and they are there to keep everyone honest while the real problem regrows behind them: individually harmless, collectively a swarm that punishes anyone who stands still. Eight Rotblooms hitting in a cloud means Spore Puff has the whole party rolling saves, so this is a proper scrap rather than a speed bump. The tell to plant quietly: nothing here attacks the little armoured digger watching from the mound, and it does not run from them. Corruption does not eat its own.*

ENEMIES, Fight 2: Chime Reef

The Chime Reef ♦ Difficulty: Hard, or easy the moment they use thunder ♦ 4x Chimestone + 4x Shardwing

CHIMESTONE

Medium elemental (Plane of Earth), unaligned ♦ CR 3 (700 XP) ♦ 4 standing up out of the shallows



AC 16 (rock plate) **HP** 78 (12d8 + 24) **Speed** 25 ft
STR 18 **DEX** 8 **CON** 14 **INT** 5 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 6
Resist piercing, slashing **Vuln.** thunder
Imm. poison ♦ (cond) charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned
Senses tremorsense 60 ft, passive Perception 11
Challenge 3 (700 XP)

Traits

Resonant Body. Whenever it takes **thunder damage** it is **stunned** until the end of its next turn, and it takes **double damage** from every source while stunned.

Struck Chord. A creature can use an action to strike one of the reef's large spires (DC 13 Athletics). Every Chimestone within 30 ft makes a DC 14 Constitution save or is stunned as above. The striker takes 1d6 thunder damage from standing that close.

Actions

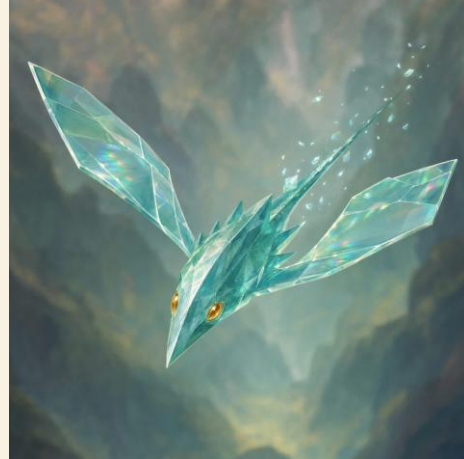
Multiattack. Two Crystal Rams.

Crystal Ram. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 11 (2d6 + 4) bludgeoning damage.

Shard Volley. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, range 40 ft. *Hit:* 9 (2d8) piercing damage.

SHARDWING

Small elemental, unaligned ♦ CR 1 (200 XP) ♦ 4 in the air above the reef



AC 14 **HP** 33 (6d6 + 12) **Speed** 10 ft, **fly** 50 ft
STR 8 **DEX** 18 **CON** 14 **INT** 4 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 6
Vuln. thunder ♦ **Imm.** poison ♦ (cond) poisoned, prone
Senses tremorsense 30 ft, passive Perception 11
Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Traits

Glide. It can fly at full speed without provoking opportunity attacks from creatures it starts its turn adjacent to.

Actions

Dive. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 9 (2d6 + 2) slashing damage. If it moved at least 30 ft straight toward the target first, this deals an extra 1d6.

Shard Spit. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, range 60 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d10 + 2) piercing damage.

Tactics: These are not corrupted. They are the reef's immune system, and the party is loud and warm and came in through a hole. **The lever is thunder.** Any thunder damage stuns a Chimestone until the end of its next turn and doubles all damage against it while it is stunned, which turns a wall with AC 16 into a free kill: Lilly's Boomstick blast, her Thunderwave and Shatter, and Ursa's Thunderwave all do it (the Nichirin is steel and force, not thunder; this one belongs to the casters), and the Shardwings are vulnerable to thunder too, so one lever answers the whole encounter. The reef itself is the second weapon: an action and a DC 13 Athletics check to strike a big spire sends the note rolling out, and every Chimestone within 30 ft saves or is stunned. The trade keeps it honest, because the striker takes 1d6 thunder from standing that close, and nobody has ever minded. Play the Chimestones as the wall and the Shardwings as the reason nobody gets to stand still: they dive, they spit from sixty feet, and they will not be pinned down. A party that never finds the lever is in a genuinely hard fight, so do not soften it before they have had their chance to be clever. Call the short rest out loud the moment the reef goes quiet: Hit Dice, Stabby's Focus, Ursa's Wild Shape, Lilly's Aether Ward.

ENEMIES, Fight 3: The Glassed Gallery

The Glassed Gallery ♦ Difficulty: The hardest fight before the boss ♦ 1x Glass Weeper + 4x Cinderoll

GLASS WEEPER

Large plant (corrupted guardian-beast), unaligned ♦ CR 6 (2,300 XP) ♦ still trying to do its job



AC 16 (black glass) **HP** 170 (20d10 + 60) **Speed** 20 ft
STR 18 **DEX** 8 **CON** 16 **INT** 4 **WIS** 12 **CHA** 5
Resist bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical weapons

Imm. poison ♦ (cond) charmed, frightened, poisoned, prone
Senses blindsight 60 ft, passive Perception 11
Challenge 6 (2,300 XP)

Traits

Glassbound. It regains 10 hit points at the start of its turn unless it took radiant or force damage, or was hit by Cleansing Edge, since its last turn.

Rooted. It cannot move more than 15 ft from the glassed roots it is tending, and it never tries to.

Tend the Roots. A creature can use an action to clear or heal the roots near it: DC 14 Nature or Medicine, or any healing spell cast on the roots rather than a creature. On a success the Weeper loses Glassbound until the end of its next turn and every attack against it has **advantage** until the start of the helper's next turn.

Actions

Multiattack. Three Frond Lashes.

Frond Lash. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 15 ft. *Hit:* 12 (2d6 + 5) slashing damage.

Keening (Recharge 5-6). 30-ft cone, DC 15 Constitution save: 21 (6d6) psychic damage and frightened until the end of its next turn; half damage and no fear on a success.

CINDEROLL

Small elemental (corrupted), unaligned ♦ CR 1/2 (100 XP) ♦ 4 in the gallery, arriving two at a time



AC 15 (glassy coal) **HP** 18 (4d6 + 4) **Speed** 40 ft (rolling)
STR 12 **DEX** 14 **CON** 12 **INT** 3 **WIS** 8 **CHA** 3

Imm. fire, poison ♦ (cond) blinded, charmed, deafened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 60 ft, passive Perception 9

Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Traits

Rolling Charge. If it moves at least 20 ft straight toward a target before hitting it, the attack deals an extra 3 (1d6) damage and the target makes a DC 12 Strength save or is knocked prone.

Burst. When it drops to 0 hit points it cracks open: each creature within 10 ft makes a DC 12 Dexterity save or takes 7 (2d6) fire damage.

Actions

Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (2d4 + 2) bludgeoning damage plus 3 (1d6) fire damage.

Tactics: The big fight before the boss, and it should be hard: the Weeper hits for real, regenerates 10 a round, and the Cinderolls roll in and detonate two at a time. **The lever is the roots.** An action spent tending them (DC 14 Nature or Medicine, or any healing aimed at the roots) strips its regeneration for a round and hands everyone advantage; it never ends the fight, it makes the party feel brilliant while they finish it. Stabby is the proving ground: only radiant, force, or Cleansing Edge shuts Glassbound off. Let the Cinderolls cluster; a chain reaction is theirs to discover. When the Weeper falls it shatters, and curled where its heart would be is a small ordinary creature, two years dead. Let the table sit with that.

ENEMIES, BOSS: Groudon's Hollow

Groudon's Hollow ♦ Difficulty: Boss, but the spike is the whole fight ♦ 1x Groudon + one Glassling every round

GROUDON, THE CONTINENT-MAKER

Gargantuan elemental (Plane of Earth, Guardian), unaligned ♦ CR 11 (7,200 XP) as run here ♦ he is not the villain, the spike is



AC 18 (mountain plate) HP 230 (but see The Spike) Speed 40 ft, burrow 40 ft

STR 26 DEX 6 CON 24 INT 8 WIS 14 CHA 12

Resist all damage from nonmagical weapons

Imm. fire, poison ♦ charmed, frightened, paralyzed, petrified, restrained, stunned

Senses tremorsense 120 ft, passive Perception 12

Traits

THE SPIKE (this is the encounter). Black glass driven into his back at the shoulder. AC 17, 60 hit points, immune to all but radiant, force, and Cleansing Edge; it re-knits 20 at the start of his turns unless Cleansing Edge touched it since his last. Reach it by climbing (DC 14 Athletics or Acrobatics), flying, or a ranged shot at disadvantage. **When it breaks the encounter ends immediately.** He is not supposed to die.

Unstoppable. He cannot be frightened, charmed, restrained, or knocked prone, and he ignores difficult terrain.

Agony. While the spike is intact, at the start of each of his turns he takes 10 damage and everything within 20 ft makes a DC 16 Dexterity save or takes 10 (3d6) bludgeoning damage from the shockwave.

He Does Not Finish Them. At 0 hit points a hero is left alone: he immediately moves away, swatting at pain, not hunting children.

Actions

Continental Step. He moves up to his speed. Every creature on the ground within 30 ft of his path makes a DC 16 Dexterity save or is knocked prone and takes 11 (2d10) bludgeoning damage.

Magma Vent (Recharge 4-6). A 60-ft line, 10 ft wide. DC 17 Dexterity save: 35 (10d6) fire damage, half on a success.

Claw. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +12 to hit, reach 15 ft. *Hit:* 24 (3d10 + 8) slashing damage.

Thrash (when the spike takes damage, 1/round, no action). Every creature climbing him makes a DC 15 Strength or Acrobatics check or falls, taking 3d6 bludgeoning damage.

GLASSLING

Tiny construct (spawned by the spike), unaligned ♦ CR 1/4 (50 XP) ♦ one new one every round the spike lives



AC 14 HP 10 (3d4 + 3) Speed 30 ft, climb 30 ft

STR 8 DEX 16 CON 12 INT 1 WIS 6 CHA 1

Imm. poison, psychic ♦ (cond) blinded, charmed, deafened, frightened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 30 ft, passive Perception 8

Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)

Traits

Spike-Born. The spike creates one Glassling at the start of each of Groudon's turns. When the spike is destroyed, every Glassling collapses into ordinary sand immediately, wherever it is and whatever it was doing.

Shatterburst. At 0 hit points, each creature within 5 ft makes a DC 12 Dexterity save or takes 5 (2d4) slashing damage.

Actions

Glass Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) slashing damage.

Tactics: Do not let the party win by damage. Groudon has more hit points than they can chew through and hits hard enough to drop a hero in two turns, so a straight brawl is a loss. The win condition is the spike: AC 17, 60 hit points, immune to everything except radiant, force, and Cleansing Edge, reached by climbing him (DC 14 Athletics or Acrobatics), by flight (Stabby's Sash), or by a called shot at range with disadvantage. Break it and the fight is over on the spot, not whittled down. The Glasslings are the answer to the obvious question, which is why not ignore the spike and whittle Groudon from range: one more of them drops off his back at the start of every one of his turns, so the longer the spike lives the more little glass things are chewing on the party, and the instant the spike goes every one of them collapses into sand at once and the whole board clears in a heartbeat. Play Groudon as a natural disaster with a wounded animal inside it rather than a tactician, alternating Continental Step, Magma Vent, Claw, and Thrash when the spike is struck. Every hero has a role: Stabby climbs a mountain that is trying to shake him off and cuts the corruption out of a god, and this is his moment, so do not let anyone else take it unless his player hands it over; Ursa keeps people standing and can put a summon between Groudon and the climber, and his Mark of Handling lets him feel that the creature is in pain, which is the line that turns the fight into a rescue; Lilly shoots the spike from range, holds the party together with Aether Ward, and Puff's Wand of Magic Missiles is force damage that never misses. If the dice go badly, let a summon pin Groudon or let Flash of Genius rescue the climb check so the last blow is still Stabby's. Mercy rule for the table: if a hero drops, Groudon does not finish them. He is not killed here. He is freed.

ENEMIES: The Road Between

Anywhere on the board ♦ Difficulty: Small pressure ♦ dot encounters only

THUMPAW

Large beast (Plane of Earth), unaligned ♦ CR 3 (700 XP) ♦ random encounters only ♦ 1, and it was there first



AC 14 (mossy hide) HP 76 (8d10 + 32) Speed 30 ft, burrow 30 ft
STR 20 DEX 8 CON 18 INT 3 WIS 12 CHA 6
Senses tremorsense 60 ft, passive Perception 13
Challenge 3 (700 XP)

Traits

Not Actually Angry. It does not attack until attacked, and it never pursues. It is in the way and it was there first.

Immovable. It has advantage on saves and checks against being moved, and it cannot be knocked prone.

Actions

Multiattack. Two Shovel Slams.

Shovel Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 10 ft. Hit: 14 (2d8 + 5) bludgeoning damage.

GLEAMOTH SWARM

Medium swarm of Tiny beasts, unaligned ♦ CR 1 (200 XP) ♦ random encounters only ♦ 3 swarms, and they want the warmest thing in the tunnel



AC 12 HP 26 (4d8 + 8) Speed 5 ft, fly 40 ft (hover)
STR 4 DEX 14 CON 14 INT 1 WIS 10 CHA 4
Resist bludgeoning, piercing, slashing Vuln. fire, thunder
Imm. (cond) charmed, frightened, grappled, prone, restrained, stunned
Senses blindsight 20 ft, passive Perception 10
Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Traits

Drawn to Warmth. It always moves toward the warmest or brightest thing it can sense, which is the Essence Sphere. If Lilly is carrying it, the swarm goes for her every turn.

Swarm. It can occupy another creature's space and move through any opening large enough for a single moth.

Actions

Smother. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 0 ft, one creature in its space. Hit: 10 (4d4) piercing damage, or 5 (2d4) if the swarm is at half its hit points or fewer, and the target is **blinded** until the end of its next turn.

Tactics: These two never appear at a scripted fight. They are what a garnet dot means, and they are the only creatures the party meets purely by luck, which is what keeps a dot roll feeling different from a story beat instead of feeling like filler. Keep them small: a little pressure, a little resource, and no more. Do not let a dot roll swell into a

fifth big fight, because the four scripted encounters are the session. Thumpaw is a straight brawl with no gimmick and no puzzle, 76 hit points and two big slams a turn, for the moments when the table simply wants to hit something large until it stops; it never pursues and it never finishes a downed hero, because it is grumpy, not evil. (If the players think of befriending it instead, a DC 15 Animal Handling check with advantage from Ursa's Mark moves it aside. Do not offer this. Let them find it.) The Gleamoths are not corrupted either, just hungry for heat: they blind and smother rather than deal much damage, fire and thunder scatter them fast, and anything that hits an area is worth double. The cost is the Sphere, which pulls them hardest, so the swarm sits on Lilly the whole fight and the rest of the party has to come to her.

◆ LORE OF ELARIA ◆ **The Two Lists**

The Circle's bestiary of the Darkening keeps two lists. The frightening one is long: the twisted, the glassed, the re-blooming, every creature the leaking dark has worn like a glove. The kind one is longer, and it is the same list, written again after somebody set them free. Corruption, the sky-readers say, is a thing that happens to a creature, never a thing that it is. Strike to free, not to punish, and a world will hand you back more friends than enemies.
